HT BENGALURU

Monday, November 2, 2026

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Imports, low base power best Oct GST jump in 4 years ▶P1

Anthropic IPO gets HNIs excited, but shares hard to get ▶P1

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HT BENGALURU VOL.1 NO.80

Monday, November 2, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Will the COP31 deliver hope or a heartbreak?

BY SAYANTAN BERA

The United Nations' annual climate summit opens amid energy crisis, wars, soaring food prices and an intensifying El Niño. As nearly 200 countries gather in Antalya, Türkiye, climate finance, fossil fuels and the costs of global warming will top the agenda. Here's what to expect.

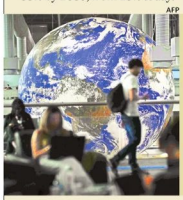
AFP

1 What is on the agenda?

The 31st Conference of the Parties (COP31), scheduled for 9-20 November, will run on two tracks. The first is formal negotiations, presided over by Australia's climate and energy minister, Chris Bowen. Key issues include $1.3 trillion in annual climate finance for developing countries, support to help vulnerable nations adapt to climate shocks, and the future of fossil fuels. The second covers the host's voluntary initiatives, from cleaner cities and waste reduction to healthier oceans and greater electrification. Its headline ambition is to raise electricity's share of global energy supply to 35% by 2035, from 23% today.

2 What is India's position?

India will likely call on developed countries to honour commitments on climate finance, adaptation support and technology transfer. It opposed unilateral trade measures like the European Union's carbon border tax, which raises costs for Indian steel and other exports, arguing climate action must account for differing needs. It can point to achieving 50% non-fossil power capacity in 2025, five years ahead of target. India's updated 2031-35 climate pledges include cutting gross domestic product (GDP) emissions intensity by 47% from 2005 levels and raising the share of non-fossil sources in installed power capacity to 60%.



AFP

3 What did the last summit achieve?

Held in November 2025, COP30 saw countries agree to work towards tripling adaptation finance by 2035 and reaffirm the goal of mobilising $1.3 trillion in annual climate finance. But the deal offered no roadmap on phasing out fossil fuels. Brazil's presidency said it would instead pursue voluntary plans on fossil fuels and deforestation.

4 Is the Paris climate goal out of reach?

The chance of limiting global warming to 1.5°C above pre-industrial levels, as envisaged by the 2015 Paris Agreement, has been lost, according to the UN's Emissions Gap Report 2026. Warming is expected to breach that threshold and peak at 1.7-1.8°C around mid-century. Returning to the 1.5°C pathway by 2100 remains possible, but would need emission cuts of 18% by 2030, 45% by 2035 and 69% by 2040 from 2025 levels, along with the removal of roughly 320 billion tonnes of carbon dioxide this century.

5 Will COP31 reckon with the 'super' El Niño?

COP31 comes as an unprecedented El Niño builds in the Pacific, with the event expected to make 2027 warmer than 2024 and potentially set a new record. El Niño compounds warming but does not alter its long-term trajectory. It could, however, offer delegates a preview of a hotter world, with more severe droughts, floods and wildfires. An October update from the University of Chicago's Climate Impact Lab projects 857,000 global deaths from El Niño-related extreme heat between June 2026 and March 2027.

QUICK EDIT

The skill premium

Referring to the widespread use of computers in the 20th century economy, Nobel-winning economist Robert Solow had famously quipped that "you can see the computer age everywhere but in the productivity statistics." One could make a similar quip about artificial intelligence (AI) and employment today. So far, economists have been unable to find strong evidence that AI usage has led to job losses.

AI could displace some workers over time. But this process may be slower than AI marketers would have us believe. Other changes in the labour market deserve more attention. Rising automation has raised demand for college-educated workers in the American manufacturing sector, *The Wall Street Journal* reported last week. Manufacturers have been hiring more white-collar workers in managerial roles even as blue-collar roles increasingly require advanced training to deal with complex automated workflows.

Even in the Indian labour market, the skill premium is likely to rise. Indian employers have been complaining about skill deficits for quite some time. Policymakers need to fix the mess in our education and skilling systems on a war footing.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

This [the proposed southern bullet train corridor] will basically combine these large economies, technology capitals, into one large economy. This will be a huge multiplier for the states in South India.

ASHWINI VAISHNAW
RAILWAY MINISTER

He was speaking after flagging off a Vande Bharat Sleeper Express between Bengaluru and Mumbai.

INSIDE

Mark to Market | VBL's growth faces a margin test >P4
Global | Behind the scenes of crypto's biggest nightmare: a record heist >P8
Money | How to declutter your stock and MF portfolios this festive season >P11
Views | India's market slump: No palliatives please >P12
Business of Life | With permission to innovate or fail, staff bring new ideas >P14

THE WEEK AHEAD

2 NOV — RENEWABLE ENERGY MEET
India to host Bharat Renewable Energy Summit & Expo in Delhi.

3 NOV — US MIDTERM ELECTIONS
Americans head to the polls for the US midterm elections.

3 NOV — PUNE METRO LINE 3
PM Modi to virtually inaugurate Pune Metro Line 3

4 NOV — ISRAEL ELECTION RESULTS
Final election results to be submitted to President Isaac Herzog.

5-7 NOV — EARNINGS THIS WEEK
Titan, Shiprocket, Voltas, Bosch, Honasa, Tata Chem, Tata Steel

8 NOV — MUHURAT TRADING
BSE and NSE to hold a special Diwali Muhurat Trading session.

COLUMNS

NITIN PAI
IBN KHALDUN'S IDEAS TELL US MUCH ABOUT OUR TECH SERVICES INDUSTRY >P12

Manu Joseph
HOW CHEAP LABOUR FROM INDIA HAS MADE LONDON KINDER >P12

Rajrishi Singhal
PUBLIC SECTOR UNITS MUST SLOW DOWN THE IMPLEMENTATION OF AI >P13

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PLAIN FACTS

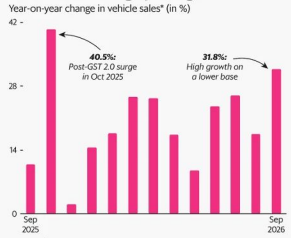
NUMBERS TO WATCH THIS WEEK

BY ANJISHNU DAS & PAYAL BHATTACHARYA

As India heads into the festive peak, automobile sales and manufacturing PMI figures will offer a fresh glimpse of consumer demand and industrial momentum. Earnings from consumer staples majors will reveal how rising food inflation and a widening rural-urban price gap are squeezing household budgets. Across the Pacific, US midterm polls will decide control of Congress and shape Washington's legislative agenda. Back home, the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit will spotlight India's estimated $220 billion investment need for clean energy infrastructure. Every Monday, *Mint's Plain Facts* tracks the economic trends, data releases and global events shaping the days ahead.

October vehicle sales hinge on festive demand amid a high year-ago base

Year-on-year change in vehicle sales* (in %)



*Across all segments.

Source: Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations, Mint calculations

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AUTO SIGNAL

AFTER ROBUST sales in September, the domestic automobile industry is heading into a high-stakes festival season, with Diwali approaching. October data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (Fada), expected this week, will offer an early indication of consumer demand during the crucial buying period. September saw vehicle sales across segments surge 31.8% year-on-year, led by major automakers such as Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra and Tata Motors. However, the growth was partly amplified by the base effect, as vehicle purchases had been deferred last year ahead of the expected cut in the goods and services tax (GST).

October will provide the first cleaner year-on-year comparison. Fada surveys point to strong dealer optimism, with more than 75% expecting sales growth to continue through the year. Yet, affordability remains a concern amid rising prices. Provisional sales data for the Navratri period, from 11-20 October, showed a 6.5% year-on-year sales decline.

BUSINESS ACTIVITY

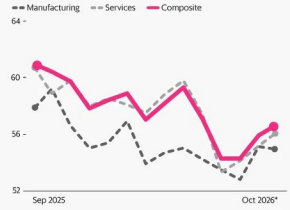
THE FINAL October Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI), due on 2 November, will offer a fuller picture of manufacturing demand, export orders and hiring as businesses prepare for the December quarter.

Manufacturing faces a more uneven outlook, with slower purchasing activity and cautious hiring contrasting with stronger order inflows. Services, meanwhile, will be assessed on their ability to sustain growth amid domestic and overseas demand. Last week, flash estimates showed composite PMI up at 56.7 in October from 55.9 in September, highest in four months. New export orders rose fastest in six months, but employment growth was at its weakest. Manufacturing PMI eased to 54.9 from 55.1, while services PMI rose to 56.2 from 55.2.

It noted that input-cost inflation eased for the seventh month in a row to a near one-year low in October, though transport and steel costs continued to pressure businesses. Firms sharply increased finished-goods inventories even as purchasing activity slowed.

Improving market conditions, strong new orders lift optimism in October flash PMI

India's purchasing manager's index, monthly



*Flash PMI figures used for October 2026. A reading above 50 denotes month-on-month expansion, and a reading below 50 denotes contraction.

Source: S&P Global

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Rising rural inflation puts FMCG demand in focus ahead of ITC, Marico Q2 results

Year-on-year retail inflation (in %)

Source: CMIE

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RURAL SQUEEZE

SEPTEMBER-QUARTER results from ITC Ltd and Marico Ltd on Monday will offer clues to the resilience of rural demand and consumer firms' ability to sustain volume growth as household costs rise. Both are part of the Nifty Rural Index, making their show a useful signal of rural consumption trends. Rural inflation rose to 6.08% in September, highest since June 2024, amid a deficient monsoon, an El Niño and an unfavourable base effect. The rural-urban inflation gap widened to a 20-month high. Rural consumption accounts for 55.4% of the CPI basket, against 44.6% for urban consumption.

Nomura expects food and beverage inflation to rise to 8.5-9% in October-November from 5.7% in August, raising the risk of weaker consumption after the festive season. In its 1 October report, Nomura also flagged the convergence of rural volume growth with urban. Investors will eye ITC's cigarette and non-cigarette businesses and Marico's Parachute and Saffola portfolios, alongside commentary on pricing, margins and rural demand in the second half of the fiscal.

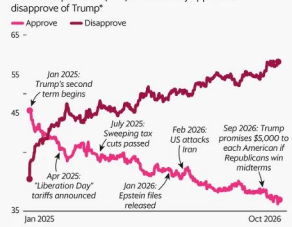
MID-TERM MANDATE

AMERICANS WILL vote in the mid-term election on 3 November, in a contest widely viewed as a referendum on President Donald Trump's performance and that of his party. Voters will elect all 435 members of the House of Representatives and 35 of the Senate's 100 members. Republicans hold majority in both chambers. Trump's approval rating has fallen to 37% from 52% in January 2025. A Pew survey showed economy and inflation among voters' top concerns, with 65% saying Trump's policies had worsened conditions. Halfway through his second term, the poll offers voters a chance to hold his administration accountable and could determine which party controls Congress and the legislative agenda.

For India, the outcome is unlikely to drastically alter ties with the US or core trade and immigration issues. Trump's presidential veto powers mean that even if the Democrats seize a majority in the House and Senate, they would be limited in impacting foreign policy, including stalled trade talks with India or the war against Iran that has sparked a global energy crisis.

Trump's approval rate down to 37% now from 52% when his term began

Share of respondents (in %) who said they approve or disapprove of Trump*



*Based on daily weighted averages of multiple professional polls.

Source: Silver Bulletin

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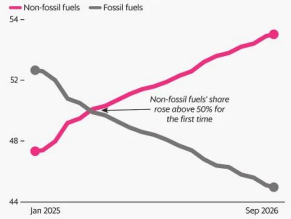
Majority of India's installed capacity have come from non-fossil fuels since June 2025

Share (in %) in installed electricity generation capacity



Non-fossil fuels include renewable sources and nuclear energy.

Source: Central Electricity Authority

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GREEN GOALS

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi will inaugurate the Bharat Renewable Energy Summit & Expo 2026 on 2 November, with the four-day event bringing together participants from over 130 countries at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi. It will be held alongside the International Solar Alliance Assembly and the International Conference on Green Hydrogen, with discussions spanning investment, technology, energy storage and manufacturing.

India seeks to turn its rapid clean energy expansion into a reliable power system. It has 308 GW of installed non-fossil fuel capacity and ranks third in renewable energy and solar capacity, and fourth in wind power and aims for 500 GW non-fossil capacity by 2030.

As of 30 September, non-fossil sources made for 55% of India's installed power capacity, having first overtaken fossil fuels in June 2025. Coal remains the largest single source, with 40.3%, followed by solar at 30.6%, wind at 10.6% and hydropower at 9.3%.

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Monday, November 2, 2026

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Bridges under troubled waters: India's infra challenge ▶P10

New investors sell in panic: Jio BlackRock's Swaminathan ▶P4

SENSEX 74,459.53 ↔ 0.00 | NIFTY 23,053.10 ↔ 0.00 | DOLLAR ₹94.96 ↔ ₹0.00 | EURO ₹106.33 ↔ ₹0.00 | OIL $111.73 ↑ $0.73 | POUND ₹127.51 ↔ ₹0.00

Imports, low base power best GST growth in 4 yrs

October is the 4th month this fiscal with GST collections crossing ₹2 trillion mark

Dhirendra Kumar
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NEW DELHI

AFP

REVENUE SPIKE

GST collections rose 22.9% year-on-year to ₹2.31 trillion in Oct

THE rise in GST mop-up comes amid a favourable base

IMPORT-related revenue recorded a 42.2% surge

India's goods and services tax (GST) collections in October clocked the fastest growth in four years, buoyed by a surge in import taxes and a favourable low statistical base from last year. The growth is the fastest on record since September 2022, data from the official GST Network and finance ministry showed.

Provisional government data released on Sunday showed gross GST collections jumped 22.9% year-on-year to ₹2.31 trillion in October, boosted by a 42.2% surge in import-related revenue and a rebound from last October's subdued consumption ahead of GST rate revisions.

Revenue from imports rose to ₹72,246 crore, while domestic GST collections grew 15.8% to ₹1.59 trillion from ₹1.37 trillion a year earlier, the data showed.

The latest growth marked a sharp acceleration from the 4.6% recorded in October last year, and also exceeded the 8.9% growth seen in October 2024, 13% in October 2023 and 16.6% in October 2022.

The rise in GST mop-up comes amid a favourable base. October 2025 was the first full month after tax rate rationalization took effect in September.

"October's GST growth was driven by both sequential gains and a favourable base effect, as collections in October last year were relatively low," said Madhavi Arora, chief economist at Emkay Global.

Some other experts, however, said the latest growth remains significant as it comes with the tax rates lowered. "Before the reforms, GST had four main slabs of 5%, 12%, 18% and 28%. The revised structure largely moved to two main slabs of 5% and 18%, with a higher 40% rate only for select demerit and luxury goods. The growth indicates GST revenue mobilization has remained strong despite rationalization of tax rates," said Saurabh Agarwal, tax partner at EY India.

October marked the fourth month this fiscal in which GST collections topped the ₹2 trillion mark and the second-highest monthly mop-up on record, after the ₹2.43 trillion collected in April 2026. Collections were at ₹2.11 trillion in July and ₹2.04 trillion in September.

The sharp rise in import-linked collections points to stronger revenue mobilization from imported goods, although the data does not distinguish between the effects of higher import volumes and changes in import values. Domestic revenue accounted for nearly 69% of gross GST collections in October, with imports contributing the remaining 31%. The government will detail October imports data mid-November.

Net GST collections, after refunds, rose 25.6% to ₹2.03 trillion from ₹1.62 trillion a year earlier, outpacing the growth in gross

TURN TO PAGE 6

Anthropic IPO gets HNIs excited, but shares hard to get

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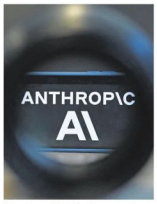

Stock availability is scarce in private markets. AFP

India's ultra-rich are seeking shares in Anthropic ahead of its much-anticipated initial public offering (IPO), encouraged by the blockbuster listing of SpaceX in June and the scarcity of domestic artificial intelligence (AI) investment opportunities.

Wealth managers are fielding inquiries from technology founders, family offices, and business executives across the country, after the maker of Claude filed papers for its IPO last week. However, stock availability is scarce in private markets, and access for anyone outside major American and European markets is expected to be extremely limited, they said on condition of anonymity.

"Quite a few of our clients have enquired more than once over the last week about investment opportunities in Anthropic. But getting them those shares is easier said than done at this point," a Mumbai-based wealth manager for ultra-high-networth individuals said.

Anthropic represents a compelling opportunity at the intersection of AI and enterprise technology, and a certain fear-of-missing-out factor around such a marquee listing is inevitable among HNIs, said Prakash Bulusu, joint chief executive at IIFL Capital. While tech entrepreneurs, globally oriented family offices and younger-generation business leaders are natural early adopters of global AI investments, "Traditional business families are also exploring the theme, viewing AI as a long-term portfolio opportunity," he said.

SpaceX made a historic stock market debut in June, surging over 30.8% on Day

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS

MINT

Air India weighs Singapore Airlines executive for CFO

Air India is mulling appointing an executive from its investor, Singapore Airlines, as its next CFO, a move that underscores the Singaporean carrier's growing operational involvement in the Tata-owned airline as it works to chart a path to profitability. >P5

Cybercrime surge boosts demand for legal experts

Cyber fraud is becoming a bigger and more complex threat for India Inc. Now, with AI-enabled scams adding to the risks, white-collar crime teams at law firms are seeing a 20-30% rise in cybersecurity-related advisory and investigation work. >P5

Insurers want Irdai expense caps linked to business size

Insurers have urged the Irdai to adopt scale-based regulations, arguing that uniform expense limits could disadvantage smaller and newer players as the regulator moves to tighten controls on operating costs and distribution commissions. >P7

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Diwali demand uneven as costs bite

Soumya Gupta
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Food and grocery recorded among the highest growth. MINT

India's consumer economy is showing uneven signs of growth ahead of Diwali, with some segments reporting robust demand while others remain subdued amid high inflation, rising input costs and a shift in the festive season from the September to the December quarter.

Food and grocery recorded among the highest growth rates in July and August, at 12% year on year in the latest months for which data are available, according to consulting firm Deloitte's latest Consumer Signals report for India. Apparel growth picked up to 10% in August, while durables and electronics grew 7% during these months.

Jewellery sales growth moderated from more than 8% in August to just over 4% in September, according to data from the Retailers Association of India (RAI). The industry body said the shift in the timing of festivals from the second to the third quarter affected the numbers.

TURN TO PAGE 4

Africa e-bike co tests Bajaj, TVS

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Shift to e-motorcycles is being led by East Africa. BLOOMBERG

Bajaj Auto and TVS Motor built their presence in Africa over decades, through investment in distribution and a focus on commercial riders. Now a shift to electric motorcycles, led by East Africa, is beginning to challenge their petrol-powered models.

Among the emerging players is Spiro, a Dubai-headquartered electric motorcycle and battery-swapping company founded by Indian entrepreneur Gagan Gupta. The company claims to be Africa's largest electric motorcycle seller and is rapidly expanding its presence across the continent.

Spiro currently sells around 17,000 electric motorcycles a month, translating into an annualized volume of 204,000 units. This is equivalent to about 13% of the combined exports of Bajaj and TVS, estimated at around 1.5 million units in the region. As per estimates of consultancy InsightEV, Bajaj and TVS hold nearly half of the total motor-

TURN TO PAGE 6

Japanese deal rush keeps law firms busy

Sneha Shah &
Devina Sengupta
MUMBAI

The growing activity has translated into more business for law firms advising Japanese clients. ISTOCKPHOTO

Japanese money is flowing into India, and the lawyers who handle large deals are feeling the surge. Japan desks at leading Indian law firms are reporting their busiest stretch in recent memory, with some adding lawyers and others racing to capture a bigger share of a growing fee pool.

The momentum shows in a run of investments and partnerships announced over the past 12-18 months. MUFG Bank acquired a 20% stake in Shriram Finance, launched a dedicated venture capital fund for Indian start-ups and signed a strategic partnership with State Bank of India. Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corp. took a 20% stake in Yes Bank, and Mizuho Securities plans to acquire a controlling stake in Avendus Capital. The Development Bank of Japan invested in HDFC Capital's H-Dream Fund.

"Due to the increasing deal flow between India and Japan, across M&A and venture and PE investments, our lawyers covering the India-Japan corridor are finding themselves the busiest in the last 12-18 months," said Abhishek Guha, partner, corporate practice, at Trilegal. "We are eyeing an increased volume of M&A and PE-related activity in this corridor going forward and are gearing up for a busy time ahead."

The growing engagement comes amid shifting global geopolitics, the Russia-Ukraine war and rising US tariffs, which have brought India and Japan closer. Japan was among India's largest sources of foreign direct investment (FDI) equity inflows in the first half of 2026, investing $6.26 billion during January-June, according to government data. "The India-Japan investment corridor is witnessing remarkable momentum, driven by global economic realignment, changing supply-chain strategies and India's strong growth prospects," said Rudra Kumar Pandey, partner and head of Japan desk at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co.

Last year, Japan pledged 10 trillion yen (around $65-100 billion) in public and private investments in India over the next decade. Since August 2025, 120 memorandums of understanding (MoUs) targeting more than ₹1 trillion in cross-border investments have been signed, government

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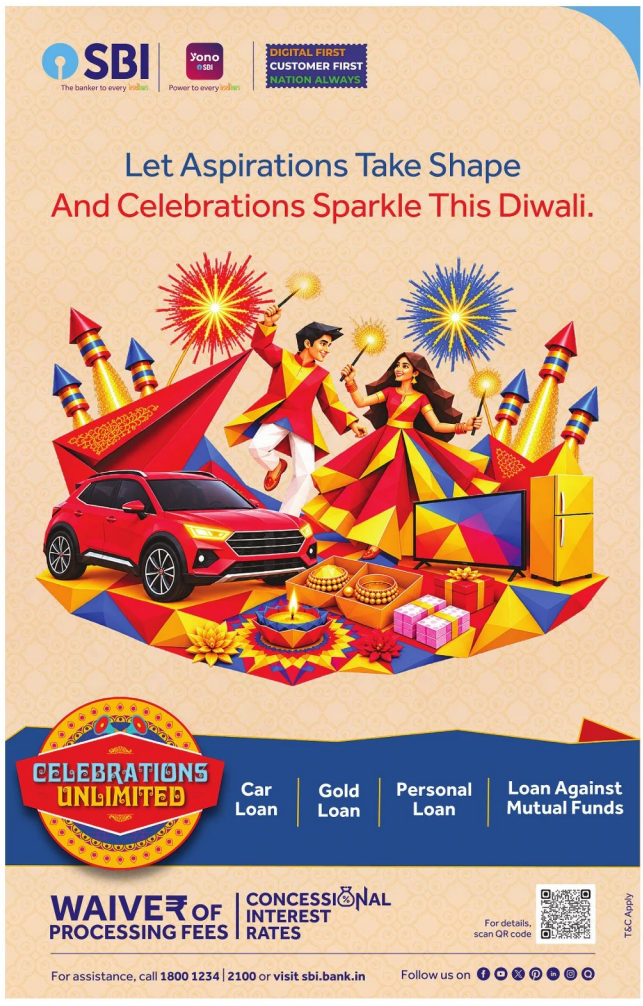

STRAIGHT FORWARD
SHASHI SHEKHAR

Respond to this column at feedback@livemint.com

CHINA'S BLUSTER MEETS AN INDIA THAT WON'T BUCKLE

History's strange turns can have tragic consequences. In October and November 1962, as winter's bitter chill began to set in, Chinese troops drew India into a devastating conflict that ended in a crushing national setback.

Today, 64 years later, the political cauldron is being stirred again over purported incursions in the Northeast. While the government has cleared the air, faceless keyboard warriors and an anxious opposition remain up in arms.

The only departure from that bygone era is an ironic twist of political fortunes. The ideological heirs of those who raised hell in 1962 are now in power, while the political descendants of that era's ruling establishment occupy the opposition benches.

However, an uncomfortable reality lies beneath the din. The Diwali lights and even the sacred idols of Ganesha and Lakshmi are overwhelmingly imported from China. Chinese products are pervasive in everyday Indian life, while India's footprint in the Chinese market remains negligible.

We must strengthen our economic muscle to the point where Beijing or any adversary thinks hard before embarking on any misadventure. The self-reliance campaign that gained momentum after the Galwan crisis has made commendable progress. But we still have a long way to go. While China remains our single largest trading partner, India barely makes it to their list of top 10 or 12 trading relationships.

Beijing's authoritarian machinery acts as an impediment against people-to-people connection between the two countries.

In June this year while strolling through the scenic coastal town of Qinhuangdao, I asked my young Chinese guide what he knew about India. "Very little," he replied bluntly, "because we only read and see what the state wants us to see."

Due to historical ambiguities, the Line of Actual Control (LAC) acts as a de facto but un-delineated boundary between the two Asian giants. In the absence of clarity on the ground, patrols from both sides occasionally stray into overlapping territory, resulting in friction. Yet, barring the bloody clash in Galwan, both nations have often exercised restraint to avert all-out hostilities.

> China may well be an economic and military heavyweight, but India is no pushover

The catalyst for the present row can be traced back to a viral video featuring the outgoing Director General of the Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP), Shatrujeet Kapur. He said the standoff that flared up in July remains unresolved. Digital provocateurs seized upon the clip and ran with it, unleashing an avalanche of alarmist commentary. By the same evening, the external affairs ministry tried to clear the air and ITBP scrubbed the video from its official handle.

Anyone tracking border infrastructure would know that roads, tunnels and rail construction are being built on a war footing. Forward landing grounds and airfields have been extensively modernized to ferry heavy armour, logistics and reinforcements.

Furthermore, sophisticated Heron Mk II surveillance drones and all-weather perimeter sensors have been deployed to detect and deter clandestine intrusions, backed from space by dedicated military reconnaissance satellites like RISAT and EMISAT.

Battle-hardened from Siachen and Kargil fronts, India's mountain infantry remains peerless in high-altitude warfare. Their tactical edge was proven post-Galwan when they pre-emptively secured the heights along the Kailash Range in full tactical gear.

The sceptics should refresh their memories of the watershed clashes of September and October 1967 at Nathu La and Cho La. Riding high on their 1962 victory, Chinese commanders arrogantly demanded that Indian forces vacate both strategic passes, by launching a series of incursions. To put an end to the intrusions once and for all, Major General Sagat Singh ordered the erection of a defensive barbed-wire perimeter.

Chinese troops opened indiscriminate fire on 11 September, killing several of our soldiers. Gen Sagat Singh unleashed heavy artillery to pound enemy fortifications into submission. Weeks later, on 1 October, brave Gorkha jawans at Cho La drew their *khukris* and repelled the intruders in a ferocious hand-to-hand combat. Over 300 Chinese soldiers were reportedly neutralized, against 88 Indian martyrs. The message was bold, cold and clear—India would never again be cowed down by a bully. Today, instead of calling the frontier villages the "last posts" of India, the government has redefined them as the first line of defence in a significant morale-boosting exercise. China may well be an economic and military heavyweight, but India is no pushover. We can ably defend our "first villages" and its valiant citizens.

India steps up crude buys from Gulf, Russia

India's crude oil imports surged to a record high of 5.6 mbpd in October

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India's crude oil imports surged to a record high of about 5.6 million barrels per day in October, with refiners stepping up purchases from the Middle East and Russia despite ongoing geopolitical tensions, according to data from energy intelligence firm Kpler.

Middle Eastern supplies accounted for about 2.3 million barrels per day (bpd), and Russian crude flows remained strong at around 2 million bpd, Kpler lead analyst Nikhil Dubey said in a post.

Higher ship-to-ship transfers helped move more crude through the Strait of Hormuz, supporting a recovery in Gulf supplies during September and October and giving Indian refiners greater flexibility in sourcing.

Russian shipments could moderate in November and December as attacks in the Black Sea push up freight rates, making those barrels less competitive on a landed-cost basis. At the same time, Gulf suppliers are offering competitive delivered prices to regain market share in India, Dubey said.

However, any renewed disruption to flows through the Strait of Hormuz could prompt Indian refiners to return to Russian crude, even if transportation costs rise.

The 16 October waiver under the Graham Act could also ease concerns among some Indian buyers about the risks associated with purchasing Russian oil, giving refiners greater flexibility in procurement, he said.

Any renewed disruption to flows through the Strait of Hormuz could prompt Indian refiners to return to Russian crude, even if transportation costs rise. REUTERS

90%
The amount of crude oil which India imports

India imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements, making the availability and landed cost of alternative supplies critical to refinery economics. The choice between Russian and Middle Eastern barrels is therefore likely to remain driven by commercial considerations and supply security rather than geopolitics alone.

Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 upended global oil trade flows, prompting Western countries to impose sanctions, an EU ban on seaborne Russian crude and a G7 price cap.

With European buyers shunning Russian oil, Moscow offered steep discounts to attract alternative markets, and India emerged as a major buyer, sharply increasing imports from negligible levels before the war to as much as 40-50% of its crude basket at their peak.

Indian refiners were drawn by the price advantage, with Russian Urals at times trading around $30 a barrel below Brent in late 2022 and early 2023. The shift transformed Russia into one of India's largest crude suppliers, as refiners prioritised cheaper landed costs and supply security over Western pressure to curb purchases.

Discounts have, however, almost vanished now, but the disruption in supplies from the Middle East has meant that Indian refiners stick to Russian barrels.

Digi Yatra trials start at seven airports for international flyers

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The civil aviation ministry on Sunday said Digi Yatra trials for international passengers have started at seven airports and the wider rollout of the facility is expected in 2027.

It will be available on a trial basis for Indian nationals holding e-passports for select international flights of Air India and IndiGo.

Based on facial recognition technology, Digi Yatra provides for contactless and seamless movement of passengers at various checkpoints at airports. It is currently available at various domestic airports.

In a release, the ministry said Digi Yatra trials for international passengers are being conducted at seven airports—Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Cochin, Mumbai, Chennai and Amritsar. Feedback received during the trial period from November to December this year will be utilised for the planning of the wider rollout of the technology in 2027.

According to the ministry, the trials will allow eligible Indian nationals holding e-passports to use the Digi Yatra at designated airport touchpoints while travelling on select international flights operated by Air India and IndiGo.

"Eligible passengers will be able to use the facility at terminal entry points, Security Hold Areas (SHA) and boarding gates, wherever the required infrastructure is available," the release said.

Digi Yatra allows contactless movement of passengers at various airports. BLOOMBERG

The ministry said the facility is to complement and not replace existing travel processes. "Passengers must continue to carry their travel documents and complete all mandatory airline document checks, immigration procedures and other applicable travel formalities," it added.

For international travel, eligible Indian nationals must create an e-passport-based Verifiable Credential through the Digi Yatra mobile application. The process involves scanning the Machine Readable Zone of the e-passport, reading the embedded chip using the Near Field Communication feature of a compatible smartphone, capturing a selfie and verifying the details, the release said.

Govt cracks down on Korean cosmetic over fat-loss claims

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India's apex drug regulator has cancelled the import registration certificate of a South Korean cosmetic product FatX solution, marketed by Delhi-based Tekno Midas Aesthetics, for making misleading therapeutic claims about dissolving fat cells, according to the two officials and a regulatory document reviewed by Mint.

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) found that the firm marketed the product on its website as a treatment to "dissolve fat cells and reduce their size". It ruled that such claims fall under the definition of a drug and do not qualify as a cosmetic under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.

Under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, cosmetics are defined as products applied by rubbing, pouring, sprinkling, or spraying solely to cleanse, beautify, boost attractiveness, or alter visual appearance.

CDSCO ruled that therapeutic claims fall strictly under the drug regulations.

Emphasizing that dissolving fat cells alters cellular and physiological structures, the CDSCO ruled that therapeutic claims fall strictly under drug regulations. Marketing the product with such claims violates the Cosmetics Rules, 2020, which bar companies from misleading consumers.

"Prohibition against false or misleading claims. No cosmetic may purport or claim to purport or convey any idea which is false or misleading to the intending user," read the document, citing the rule.

The regulator said it conducted a detailed scrutiny of the registration documents alongside the importer's official website, which uncovered huge mismatches between what had been legally cleared and what was actively marketed to the public. "Discrepancies/mismatches have been observed with respect to the availability of claims on the marketed product labels against the approved product label. On the website, the product is being marketed as treatment for dissolving the fat cells and reduces the size of fat cells which are drug claims and does not attract the definition of cosmetics," the document read.

After these violations were detected, the licensing authority served a show-cause notice to the firm on 10 August 2026. However, when the company submitted its response on 1 September 2026, it failed to provide a valid defense and instead requested the regulator to accept a voluntary surrender of its licence, the regulator said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Govt plans toll waiver for private cars of 1.4 mn defence personnel

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The Centre plans to grant toll exemptions to the private vehicles of 1.4 million active defence personnel to resolve a unique challenge with barrier-less highway tolling—where e-challans are being issued to armed forces personnel using private vehicles on highways equipped with multi-lane free flow (MLFF) systems.

The ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) has initiated discussions with the defence ministry to develop a mechanism allowing free pass to these private vehicles without disrupting traffic flow. One proposal involves equipping such vehicles with FASTags, with the annual pass cost reimbursed by the defence ministry.

However, people aware of the development said discussions remain inconclusive over who should bear the expense of the pass.

Another option under consideration is a differentiated FASTag that records vehicle movement but does not deduct toll charges.

The road transport ministry has initiated discussions with the defence ministry. MINT

The move is aimed at preventing delays in the nationwide rollout of MLFF, which is expected to cover the country's entire network of about 1,150 toll plazas by the end of FY28. MoRTH had earlier indicated that the system could be available across almost the entire toll plaza network by the end of this year. However, fewer than 10 toll plazas currently have MLFF, while bids have been invited for over 100 more. The ministry expects another 300-400 toll plazas to be bid out by the end of this financial year.

Under the existing system, private vehicles of armed forces personnel can claim exemption from toll payments by displaying their identity cards at toll plazas.

However, with MLFF eliminating physical barriers and manual verification, vehicles without a digitally recognized exemption risk receiving e-challans for unpaid tolls.

The issue has already surfaced on highway stretches where MLFF has been introduced, with e-challans being issued to armed forces personnel using their private vehicles under the existing exemption arrangement, the people said.

"We are testing the technology and want to resolve issues like these before the system becomes available nationally," a government official said, requesting anonymity.

Queries emailed to MoRTH and the defence ministry went unanswered.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

India plans to nominate Chhath Mahaparv, others for Unesco recognition

Harsh Kumar & Utpal Bhaskar
NEW DELHI

The Centre plans a global campaign to showcase India's cultural traditions and project its soft power through shared heritage with other countries. The strategy includes jointly nominating Chhath Mahaparv with Mauritius for Unesco recognition, culture secretary Vivek Aggarwal told *Mint* in an interview.

He said India had identified other potential Unesco nominations and was working with partner countries to advance them. These include seeking World Heritage status for sites associated with Mahatma Gandhi's Satyagraha movement in South Africa and India.

Other proposals focus on archaeological links between the Indus-Saraswati civilization and sites in Oman and Bahrain, as well as shared heritage linked to the migration of Indians to Mauritius, Suriname, Fiji and Guyana.

The government is also exploring joint Unesco recognition for other forms of intangible cultural heritage. These include shadow puppetry traditions in India, Indonesia and other Southeast Asian countries; Buddhist chanting; manuscript traditions linking India with Southeast Asia and China; and textile practices such as batik. Turban-tying traditions across Asian countries are also being considered.

Project Mausam and Project Brihattar Bharat highlight India's historical and civilizational connections with other countries.

Also, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) is undertaking conservation and related work in countries including Myanmar, Thailand, Vietnam, Indonesia and Mongolia, he said.

"You must have noticed when the Honourable Prime Minister (Narendra Modi) went to Indonesia, then he went to the site of those temples which are actually... We are helping them. We are helping, and the ASI is working there in many countries," he said.

Joint nominations would enable participating countries to present shared heritage collectively. Aggarwal said India had not previously participated in the joint nomination process for world heritage sites.

These initiatives are part of the ministry's wider efforts under Project Mausam and Project Brihattar Bharat to highlight the country's historical and civilizational connections with other countries.

While Project Brihattar Bharat seeks to highlight cultural and spiritual connections between India and other countries, including the spread of Buddhist thought and Indian temple architecture across Southeast Asia, Project Mausam has India working with other countries to pursue joint nominations of heritage sites for Unesco world heritage status.

Project Mausam draws on historical maritime trade routes and cultural exchanges across the Indian Ocean, through which Indian civilization interacted with societies in other countries.

Aggarwal cited Angkor (Cambodia) as an example of the influence of Indian temple architecture and said the government was seeking to work with partner countries to establish international recognition of shared cultural links.

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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Growth bets top TechM's agenda

Firm shifts focus to growth as it nears its margin target

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BENGALURU

Tech Mahindra's revenue grew 0.67% a quarter under CEO Mohit Joshi, trailing key peers. MINT

Tech Mahindra Ltd is close to achieving its operating margin target, and the focus has now shifted to growth, according to chief executive Mohit Joshi. The company is also aiming to further narrow the gap with mid-sized rivals that are growing faster.

In a virtual interaction with *Mint* on Tuesday, chief executive Mohit Joshi said the country's fifth-largest IT services company is focussing on narrowing the gap with its mid-sized peers. This, as it nears the fag end of its three-year transformation plan, outlined in April 2024.

The company is lagging peers on the growth front. Tech Mahindra's revenue rose an average of 0.67% per quarter, while Infosys Ltd managed 0.9%, HCL Technologies Ltd 0.79%, and LTM Ltd 1.2% since Joshi took over.

"Our priority is very much going to be on growth and some level of margin expansion that goes along with growth. But the polestar for us, as you said, is very clearly growth," said Joshi. Big acquisitions are off the table till April 2027.

Tech Mahindra ended last quarter with $1.69 billion in revenue, up 2% sequentially. For now, he is not perturbed by the growth of its mid-sized peers.

"As far as the growth with the mid-caps is concerned, you will notice that we have been bridging the gap," said Joshi. "I don't feel there is anything structural that gives mid-caps a long-term advantage in terms of growth," he added.

He said the firm's client roster and large scale can work to its advantage. "I felt that we were able to give the benefits of scale because scale has certain advantages, right? You're able to cover for a client all the job fees, you're able to provide all the service lines, you have enough depth in the industry from working with their peers, you have a degree of financial stability, and you are able to attract talent."

Joshi's statement comes after Tech Mahindra ended last year with 2% full-year growth and is now preparing the ground to compete with the growth seen among smaller mid-cap peers. Coforge Ltd, Persistent Systems Ltd, and Mphasis Ltd ended last year with gains of 29%, 17%, and 7%, respectively.

Despite the optimism, Joshi had an unachieved goal as he nears three years as CEO this December. "I think the financial services growth for us has been a little bit slower than what I expected. Now, I do feel that we have created the critical mass in terms of the teams, we have opened a couple of fairly large logos, so I feel optimistic about the road ahead," said Joshi. The firm gets 16% of its revenue from financial institutions.

Joshi, who spent over two decades at Infosys before joining Tech Mahindra, was in charge of $5.5 billion, or a third of its revenue at the time. This included its healthcare and financial services businesses. For now, the firm is not banking on acquisitions until April 2027, unlike some of its peers which have even taken on debt to buy growth and new capabilities.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

STRATEGIC RESET

CEO Mohit Joshi says scale, client relationships and wider services give a competitive edge

THE company's financial services growth has lagged expectation but new client wins give hope

MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

Market corrections: How to stay calm during volatility

smarTomorrows by CANARA ROBECO Mutual Fund
An Investor education and awareness initiative

Every investor enjoys seeing markets rise, but periods of decline are a natural part of investing. These temporary declines, referred to as market corrections, can tempt anxious investors to change their investment strategy. Understanding why corrections happen and how to respond can help investors make more informed decisions instead of reacting emotionally.

A market correction is generally a temporary decline in market prices after a period of strong gain. Corrections may be triggered by economic developments, global events, changes in interest rates, or shifts in investor sentiment. While they can be unsettling, corrections have historically been a regular feature of financial markets rather than an exception.

For long-term investors, a correction does not necessarily mean that their financial goals have changed. Instead, it serves as a reminder that markets move in cycles, and short-term fluctuations are often part of the journey towards long-term wealth creation.

Ms Investor: The market has fallen by nearly 15% over the last few weeks. I'm thinking of redeeming my mutual fund investments before prices fall even further.

Mr Mutual Fund: It's understandable to feel concerned during market declines. However, making investment decisions based solely on short-term market movements may not always be beneficial. Markets have experienced corrections many times in the past, and many have eventually recovered over the long-term.

Consider an investor who started a monthly Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) for a long-term goal. During a market correction, the Net Asset Value of the mutual fund may decline, allowing the same SIP amount to purchase more units than before. As markets recover over time, these additional units may contribute to long-term wealth creation. This illustrates how disciplined investing can help investors navigate periods of volatility.

Different approaches during a market correction may influence investor behaviour as shown in the table below.

During a Market Correction	A Disciplined Investor	An Emotional Investor
Market falls sharply	Continues investing based on financial goals	Stops SIPs or redeems investments in panic
Focus	Long-term objectives	Short-term market movements
Decision Making	Based on financial plan	Driven by fear and uncertainty
Market Recovery	Continues participating	May miss part of the recovery while waiting to re-enter

Mr Investor: So, should I simply ignore market corrections?

Mr Mutual Fund: Understand them rather than ignoring them. It's always good to stay informed about market developments. However, before changing your investment strategy, ask yourself whether your financial goals, investment horizon, or risk appetite have changed. If they haven't, short-term market volatility alone may not warrant major changes to your portfolio.

Ms Investor: What should I do when markets become volatile?

Mr Mutual Fund: Review your financial plan periodically, maintain an appropriate asset allocation, and continue investing according to your goals. Volatility is temporary, but long-term financial goals often remain unchanged.

Market corrections are an inevitable part of investing, not a signal that investing has failed. While no one can predict when markets will rise or fall, investors can control how they respond. By staying disciplined, maintaining a long-term perspective, and avoiding emotional decisions, investors can navigate market volatility with greater confidence and remain focused on achieving their financial goals.

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

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CLOSE	74,459.53	CLOSE	23,053.10	CLOSE	21,895.90	CLOSE	67,709.10	CLOSE	23,971.55	CLOSE	15,521.49	CLOSE	6,557.02
1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	1.83	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	2.00	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	2.19	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	2.86	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	2.16	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	2.50	1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	1.81
1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	2.73	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1.91	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-0.80	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-2.92	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	1.00	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.93	1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.27
3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-4.45	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.20	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.24	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.86	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.51	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-8.46	3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-6.71
6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.19	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.94	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.47	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-2.78	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.71	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-3.52	6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-1.57
1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-11.78	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-10.92	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-8.16	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-3.39	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-9.61	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-5.86	1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	-5.72

After the listing of Jio Platforms, analysts are indicating a nearly 15% hike by the telecom operator in FY27. AFP

Jio defers tariff hikes, eyes 10-15 global partners

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NEW DELHI

Fresh from its stock market debut, Jio Platforms is looking beyond mobile tariff hikes to drive revenue growth, with plans to expand its digital services business and take its technology overseas.

The company may also look "at 10-15 partners" for its international venture, managing director Akash Ambani said, in response to a question.

Jio does not want to rely solely on charging subscribers more and will decide on tariff increases at an apt time, depending on market conditions and the broader economic environment, the management told analysts on Friday.

"As a company, we don't want to use it (tariff hike) as the only lever of growth. What we want, we have capability of creating a technological layer, we want to stress that as a more sustainable way of doing it," Ambani said.

Tariff hikes are key to boost Arpu of operators, a critical metric measuring average revenue per subscriber

The statement is significant as it's been 2.5 years since telecom operators took an across-the-board hike in headline tariffs. Analysts and investors are speculating about a tariff hike for over a year, as it is seen necessary to boost return on capital employed for operators. And now, after the listing of Jio Platforms, analysts are indicating a nearly 15% hike in FY27. Tariff hikes are key to boost average revenue per user (Arpu) of operators, a critical metric measuring average revenue per subscriber. Higher tariffs help firms improve revenue growth, profitability and cash flows.

"We want to focus on how we add more value to customers and thereby increasing the realization that we have from customers," said Anshuman Thakur, chief strategy officer of Jio Platforms said during the call, adding that Jio wants to focus more on the digital services that it is offering to the customers.

"Even today, if you look at our growth trajectory, Arpu has grown by almost 3.5%. Around 4-5% growth in Arpu just because of customer mix changing, people consuming more is happening organically," Thakur said. "Our realizations from customer has grown faster, the bid which goes into JPL (Jio Platforms), which is where we are offering digital services and customers are paying for that separately is growing faster and that's a focus area for us."

In the September quarter, the firm's Arpu rose 1.5% sequentially and 3.5% year-on-year to ₹218.80 a month in the September quarter, from ₹215.60 in the preceding quarter.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

VBL's growth faces a margin test

Harsha Jethmalani
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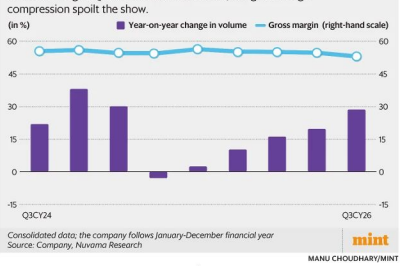
PepsiCo bottler Varun Beverages Ltd's (VBL) solid volume growth in the September quarter (Q3CY26) was overshadowed by margin compression. Investors didn't take this well, pulling the stock down 5.5% on Friday. The company follows a January-December financial year, and the September quarter is its third.

VBL's consolidated volume grew 28.7% year-on-year to 354.4 million cases in Q3CY26, driven by 22.5% growth in India and 39.9% in international markets. India volume growth, aided by a low base and favourable weather, was a key highlight, especially after disappointment in the previous quarter, and momentum continued in October, said Jefferies India.

India volume growth in Q2CY26 was 14.4%. DAM Capital noted that in CY25, a weak summer coincided with the expansion of Campa Cola (operated by Reliance Consumer Products), making it difficult to separate the impact of weather from competition. However, with a normal summer, India volume growth in Q2CY26 and Q3CY26, suggests the slowdown was largely weather led, DAM Capital said, adding that double-digit growth will continue.

Not fizzy enough

Varun Beverages' Q3CY26 volume was robust, but gross margin compression spoilt the show.



Consolidated data; the company follows January-December financial year
Source: Company, Nuvama Research
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Consolidated revenue rose 33.2% year-on-year to ₹6,607 crore in Q3CY26, beating consensus estimates, while beverage realization per case increased 2.2%. India unit realization inched up by 0.5%, reversing recent declines, aided by premiumization and trade spend rationalization. However, improved realizations and robust volumes could not offset the pressure from higher packaging costs, including preforms, shrink films, closures, and cans, driven by geopolitical disruptions.

Consequently, gross margin shrank 334 basis points (bps) year-on-year to 53.1% in Q3CY26. Elevated packaging costs eroded almost 300 bps from India gross margin, and 272 bps internationally. Overall Ebitda margin drop was curtailed to 140 bps year-on-year to 21.6%.

Management's outlook is cautiously optimistic, indicating that the full impact of cost inflation has been reflected in Q3CY26. Based on current input-price trends, management expects gross margins to stabilize, assuming there are no further adverse macroeconomic developments. To be sure, the cost inflation problem is not unique to Varun Beverages. So, it expects the broader industry to respond through price hikes or reduced trade spending, and plans to follow suit.

TIGHTROPE WALK

VBL has not hiked prices of carbonated soft drinks, but has reduced grammage in Sting to 250 ml

BUT it would follow suit if industry hikes prices or cuts trade spends amid inflation

Varun Beverages has not undertaken hikes in its carbonated soft drinks portfolio, but has reduced grammage in Sting from 300 ml to 250 ml. Also, it is not worried about competition from small/unorganized regional companies. It is not looking to compete at unviable lower price points and remains focused on ₹20, ₹50 and ₹100 prices.

After muted distributor investment in CY26, it plans aggressive numeric and weighted distribution expansion in CY27. It now reaches about 4.2 million outlets and aims to add around 200,000 outlets annually. It has earmarked a capex of ₹1,000 crore for the India business and $90-100 million for international capacity expansions.

But some analysts are wary about this. Planned CY27 capex entails significant investment, while returns from newer initiatives such as KIVA's ready-to-drink and alcobev businesses remain uncertain, said Nuvama Research. DAM Capital cut its CY27 earnings per share estimates by 6.5% to factor in higher depreciation due to large capex.

In Q3CY26, depreciation and finance costs increased by 34.5% and 53.5% year-on-year, respectively, due to the acquisition of Twizza in South Africa and the associated debt funding. This constrained growth in profit after tax. Amid worries of intensifying competition from Campa, shares of Varun Beverages are down 20% so far in CY26. Its challenge therefore lies in sustaining volume growth along with margins.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Festive demand sends mixed signals as shoppers turn cautious

FROM PAGE 1

Rising oil and commodity prices are adding to the pressure on consumer goods companies, raising the prospect of further price increases that could weigh on demand. Brent crude above $110 a barrel remains a major headwind for India, which imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements. Higher interest rates may also challenge big-ticket purchases such as cars and homes.

"Rising interest rates may dampen festive-season demand for consumer durables by increasing EMI costs and making credit-dependent consumers more cautious," said Shiv Sharma, principal at Gurugram-based Kanvic Consulting. "Buyers may defer upgrades, trade down to affordable models or rely more heavily on discounts, particularly for high-ticket products. The impact depends on how quickly higher policy rates translate into retail lending rates."

Inflation has prompted consumer goods companies across categories to raise prices over the past few quarters, largely as the cost of plastic packaging and other crude-linked inputs rose amid the West Asia war.

Yet, packaged food and everyday essentials companies are reporting resilient festive-season demand. Consumers continue to spend on premium, healthier and packaged products, suggesting that demand for festive essentials is relatively inelastic. Companies are also introducing premium festive products at entry-level price points to tap seasonal demand.

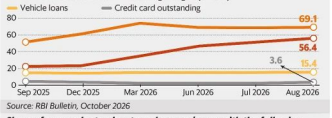
Hindustan Unilever Ltd, India's largest consumer goods company, said festive-season demand remained strong for both everyday essentials and premium products despite higher inflation.

Everyday essentials tend to be less (price) elastic, Priya Nair, chief executive and managing director of HUL, told reporters at a press briefing late last month. "The focus for us is to ensure that we are more competitive and that our brands become stronger in the context of the (inflationary) environment in which we are. We are focussing on developing the market with new formats, new products, and entry into new wide spaces."

Festive split

Ahead of Diwali, demand has remained uneven across segments.

Year-on-year growth (%)



Source: RBI Bulletin, October 2026

Share of respondents who strongly agree/agree with the following statements (%)

	September 2026	Year-on-year growth (%)
Confident about making upcoming payments	83	2 ↑
Making large purchases	60	-2 ↓
Finances same/improved within past year	78	1 ↑
Can afford to spend on things that bring me joy	39	-3 ↓
Comfortable with amount of money in savings	55	-1 ↓

The survey covered 1,000 Indian adults.
Source: Consumer Signals - India Chapter, Deloitte, October 2026
mint
MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Rival consumer goods companies are also focusing on festive launches aimed at premium buyers seeking indulgent and healthier options. These include Cadbury's new chocolate mithais and PepsiCo's protein-based laddoos and chikki bites, priced at ₹10 a pack.

"Consumers are increasingly looking beyond conventional choices and exploring new flavours, formats, and combinations to make their gifts more distinctive," Vinay Subramanyam, vice-president of marketing at confectionery maker Mondelez India, told *Mint*. "We are seeing a growing appetite for experimentation, where the experience of gifting is as important as the product itself."

"This space - which is largely premium, urban pockets is largely unfamiliar to most Indians," Saakshi Verma Menon, chief marketing officer - foods at PepsiCo India, told *Mint*. "When you look at smaller towns, that consumer knows they need to have protein but there is no access. We are democratizing the protein space with these laddoos and chikki bites."

"Parts of the old economy are firing like they have never before, primarily rural, tiered, mass consumption," Anand Ramanathan, partner and consumer industry leader at Deloitte South Asia, told *Mint*. "This is why you have seen a revival of a lot of mass brands."

Among relatively affluent urban households, however, festive spending has become more cautious.

"There is a lot of conscious spending happening on relatively affluent urban homes due to geopolitical uncertainty, services-industry based weakness," Ramanathan added. They have "become cautious because their lives are not as great as they were two years ago."

Mint previously reported that laptop sales were headed for their steepest drop in the festive season as higher memory-chip prices drove up retail prices. Executives at laptop manufacturers told Mint that many customers looking for discounts on smartphones and laptops were putting off purchases, as companies faced margins pressure.

In contrast, sales of small home and kitchen appliances are growing strongly for some consumer durables companies. Room air-conditioner sales are also holding up despite price increases by nearly all leading brands from 1 October.

"Q2 is the first time where price increase has been largely passed down, and we see positive volume growth across all categories," Kaleeswaran Arunachalam, chief financial officer of Crompton Greaves Consumer Electricals, told analysts.

Apparel sales have been affected by the shift in the festive period from the second to the third quarter, with Diwali falling later this year.

Neethi Lisa Rojan contributed to the story.

'If new investors see mkts fall 5-10%, they exit and may never return'

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INTERVIEW

Markets have remained resilient despite broadly negative returns over two years, supported by monthly SIP inflows, and this resilience could also attract foreign investors as conditions stabilize, said Sid Swaminathan, managing director and chief executive officer, JioBlackRock Asset Management. However, high SIP stoppages and cancellations point to rising investor churn, particularly among those who started investing less than two years ago, raising concerns about investor persistence. "If new investors see the market fall 5-10%, panic and exit, they may never return," Swaminathan said in an interview.

More than two-thirds of investors who panic-sell during market declines fail to return in time for the recovery, he said.

Edited excerpts:

What's your reading of the market right now and what is your outlook for the new Samvat year?

Markets have seen a meaningful reset amid geopolitical uncertainty, elevated crude prices and foreign investor selling. We remain cautiously constructive as we enter the new Samvat year. India's structural growth story remains compelling, but this is an increasingly differentiated market. That calls for greater selectivity, with a focus on where structural growth, earnings visibility and valuations come together to support sustainable returns.

Despite weak returns, SIP inflows remain strong. Are we underestimating risks around investor behaviour?

The past two years have been challenging, marked by a valuation shock in September 2024, Trump's tariffs, concerns over India's AI opportunity, and more recently, war and rising oil prices. Foreign investor outflows and a weakening rupee have added to the pressure. Yet, markets have remained resilient, with returns broadly flat over two years. Monthly SIP (Systematic Investment Plan) inflows of ₹30,000-32,000 crore have helped support the market, and this resilience could attract foreign investors once conditions stabilize. However, high SIP stoppages and cancellations point to investor churn, particularly among those who have been investing for less than two years. But investor persistence is becoming a concern. If new investors see the market fall 5-10%, panic and exit, they may never return. The industry has done a good job of simplifying access, though there is more to be done. The next challenge is to educate investors and help them stay invested, because compounding over time is what will ultimately help them build wealth.

With access expanding, what more needs to be done to keep investors invested? Should the focus now shift to building the right portfolio?

Absolutely. Until now, much of the industry's narrative has focused on products: which fund to buy and which one performs best. But with around 55-56 AMCs and 30-40 funds in some categories, there is product fatigue and too much choice for investors.

The focus needs to shift from picking the best-performing fund to understanding its role in an overall portfolio. Investors need to assess how much equity, debt and commodity exposure they need. Linking portfolios to specific outcomes will be the industry's next frontier, and this shift is already beginning.

With investment outflows from South Korea and Taiwan, could India attract some of that capital?

Initially, I expected investors to book profits in AI-focused markets and rotate money into India. India's market stability, supported by domestic investors, puts it in a good position to attract these flows. However, currency volatility and rising US interest rates are making investors cautious. This is not an India-specific issue; higher rates are dampening international investments more broadly. I remain confident that foreign flows will return once these near-term uncertainties ease. India has a strong structural growth story and offers relative value compared with other markets. Global investors tend to rotate capital after realizing gains in one market, and India is well-placed to benefit. It is a question of when, not if, these flows return.

> India has a strong structural growth story and offers relative value compared with other markets.
> **Sid Swaminathan**
> MD and CEO, JioBlackRock Asset Management

Which sectors could outperform, and where might investors find opportunities among recent laggards such as IT and FMCG?

We do not typically make broad sector calls. Our investment process is data-driven and systematic, using more than 400 signals across over 1,000 Indian stocks, alongside data analytics, machine learning and AI. Fund managers then apply their judgement. This allows us to respond quickly to new information, and portfolios may rebalance as frequently as weekly. Within IT and FMCG, investors should look beyond sector-level performance. Both have winners and losers, so stock selection is becoming increasingly important.

Rather than dismissing an entire sector, investors need to identify the companies that are performing well within it.

How should investors evaluate opportunities in lagging sectors such as IT and FMCG?

Investors should focus on individual companies' earnings growth, valuations and responses to macroeconomic trends, rather than making decisions based solely on sector performance. In IT, for instance, how companies are adapting to AI will be important. Ultimately, stock selection matters more than sector rotation, as both sectors have winners and losers.

Which sectors look promising despite recent market weakness?

Financial services stand out. As retail participation in markets grows and investor behaviour evolves, asset and wealth managers could benefit from this expanding opportunity. Credit growth is also beginning to recover after several subdued years, which could make some banking stocks attractive.

What is your advice to investors with a moderate risk appetite navigating current markets?

Stop chasing funds and returns; start thinking about your portfolio. Asset allocation should reflect your ability to absorb risk, investment horizon and financial goals. Keep money needed for near-term expenses in liquid investments, and allocate the rest across assets such as equities, fixed income, commodities and Reits (Real Estate Investment Trusts).

JioBlackRock has brought BlackRock's Aladdin platform to India and is making it available through its app. Most importantly, stay invested. More than two-thirds of investors who panic and sell after a market decline do not return in time to participate in the recovery.

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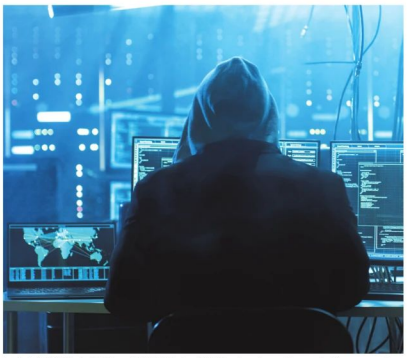
Cybercrime surge boosts demand for legal experts

Law firms see 20-30% rise in cybersecurity-related advisory and investigation work

Krishna Yadav & Yash Tiwari
NEW DELHI/MUMBAI



India's DPDP Act, 2023, and DPDP Rules, 2025, set out requirements for consent, data security, breach reporting and individuals' privacy rights. ISTOCKPHOTO

Cyber fraud is becoming a bigger and more complex threat for India Inc., with criminals impersonating company bosses, siphoning off funds and stealing customer data, sometimes through vulnerable vendors. Now, with artificial intelligence (AI)-enabled scams adding to the risks, white-collar crime teams at law firms are seeing a 20-30% rise in cybersecurity-related advisory and investigation work, lawyers said.

Their work is also shifting from routine compliance audits to risk assessment, incident response and investigations, they said. White-collar crimes are typically committed by entities.

"We have seen a significant increase, perhaps 20-30% more than previous years, in advisory work relating to criminal investigations being conducted by law enforcement agencies into various cybercrimes against or involving technology and banking companies," said Dheeraj Nair, partner at JSA Advocates & Solicitors.

Nair said JSA was advising clients on frozen bank accounts in cyberfraud cases, customer-data theft, police requests for overseas-held data, regulatory reporting and data breach disputes. Companies were also seeking proactive data protection advice. Shahana Chatterji, partner at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co., attributed the development to higher regulatory scrutiny. "We have seen a tangible increase in client questions around cybersecurity incidents, specifically on how to effectively manage and mitigate them. This is largely driven by heightened regulatory scrutiny and upcoming obligations under new privacy laws," said.

India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, and DPDP Rules, 2025, set out requirements for consent, data security, breach reporting and individuals' privacy rights. With most substantive obligations taking effect on 13 May 2027, companies are reviewing data practices, vendor notifications, communication with affected individuals and post-incident remediation.

The growing legal workload comes as companies ramp up cybersecurity spending. US technology research firm Gartner projected India's information-security spending at $3.4 billion in 2026, up 11.7% from 2025. A Tata Tele Business Services-CMR survey of 800 small and medium enterprise IT heads across eight cities found that 84% planned to increase cybersecurity budgets over the following 12-24 months.

Narasimhan Elangovan, co-founder and cyber security and data privacy practice leader at Ascentium India, said companies were investing in cybersecurity tools and talent to protect assets and build customer trust, with attacks often prompting further spending.

"After an attack, organizations learn a lot through forensics. This leads to incremental investments... Often, incidents are also wake-up calls for many organizations," he said. Elangovan said companies seek advice on incident response, regulatory reporting, vendor breaches, cyber insurance, compliance of The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDP Act), and risks associated with employees using public AI tools. The changing nature of cyber fraud is reflected in cases law firms are handling.

Kunal Gupta, partner in Trilegal's white-collar crime practice, said fraudsters were using publicly available information, including LinkedIn profiles and regulatory filings, to map corporate hierarchies and impersonate executives through spoofed WhatsApp profiles and emails.

In one case, funds were misappropriated using a spoofed executive identity created through a publicly available domain service. "A failure to notice anomalies in an email address or question an unusual payment request can allow relatively simple frauds to succeed," Gupta said.

JSA has handled cases involving theft of customer information, including credit card and know-your-customer data, through vendors and sub-vendors such as call centres working for banks. "Breaches are taking place not within the client directly, but with a vendor or sub-vendor, who is a weak link," Nair said.

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CYBERCRIME BOOM

THEIR work is shifting from compliance audits to risk assessment and investigations

COMPANIES review data practices and vendor arrangements ahead of May 2027 rules

THE growing legal workload comes as companies ramp up cybersecurity spending

GARTNER projected India's information-security spending at $3.4 billion in 2026

BoB plans overseas expansion in developed markets

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BoB is exploring opportunities across geographies, although markets and timelines are yet to be finalized. MINT

Bank of Baroda is looking to expand its international footprint, targeting wholesale banking in developed economies and retail banking in emerging markets as it seeks to build on strong growth in its overseas business.

The lender, India's second-largest public sector bank, is evaluating opportunities across geographies, although specific markets and expansion timelines are yet to be finalized, managing director and chief executive officer Debadatta Chand said in an interview with *Mint*.

"We are trying to increase our international footprint. We have seen that the growth in our international book has been very significant, and the asset quality has also been positive," Chand said, adding that the bank will announce specific markets after completing assessments and securing the necessary approvals.

The proposed expansion comes as India deepens its trade engagement and expands its network of free trade agreements, potentially creating opportunities for domestic lenders to support cross-border businesses. Chand did not identify any target markets.

India's expanding trade ties and FTA network could create opportunities for domestic lenders

Bank of Baroda already has nearly 35 directly operated branches and offices and about 45 through overseas subsidiaries. Its international network also includes an IFSC Banking Unit at GIFT City and Electronic Banking Service Units in the United Arab Emirates.

Its presence spans financial centres such as New York, London, Dubai and Singapore, alongside markets across Africa, Australia, Fiji, Mauritius and Seychelles. The network primarily serves Indian companies, cross-border trade and non-resident Indians.

As of 30 September, international advances stood at approximately ₹3.25 trillion, up 40% year-on-year, while international deposits rose 15% to ₹2.62 trillion. International business accounted for 16-17% of the bank's global business, which exceeded ₹32.5 trillion.

The lender is also stepping up efforts to mobilize overseas deposits. Under the Reserve Bank of India's special window for attracting foreign currency deposits, the lender mobilized approximately $8.08 billion through FCNR(B) deposits. Another $1.1 billion came through other routes, taking total mobilization to approximately $9.18 billion, Chand said.

FCNR(B) deposits allow non-resident Indians to hold savings in designated foreign currencies, providing banks with an additional source of overseas funding.

Bank of Baroda expects its net interest margin (NIM) to improve in the December quarter, as higher lending rates feed through faster than rising funding costs.

Nearly 38% of its loan book is linked to the repo rate, and repricing following the recent policy rate increase has already taken place. Corporate loans linked to other benchmarks, including Treasury Bill-linked rates, are also expected to lift interest income in the coming quarter.

"The last quarter would not have the full impact. Q3 is going to have the full impact. Considering that, a significant uptick is possible on the interest income side," Chand said.

Deposit costs are also expected to rise, but the bank believes it can manage the impact with a lag, supported by liquidity from its foreign currency deposit mobilization. "I am very positive about Q3 margin being better than Q2," Chand said.

It has retained its NIM guidance of 2.75-2.95% for fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

Following a strong first half, it has raised its annual growth guidance for advances to 13-15%, from 12-14% earlier, and for deposits to 11-13%, from 10-12%.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Singapore Airlines is currently represented on Air India's board by its chief executive, Goh Choon Phong. MINT

Air India weighs Singapore Airlines executive for CFO

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Air India is considering appointing an executive from its investor, Singapore Airlines, as its next chief financial officer (CFO), a move that underscores the Singaporean flag carrier's growing operational involvement in the Tata-owned airline as it works to chart a path to profitability.

Air India's management has held preliminary discussions on the appointment with Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran and Air India CEO Tewolde Gebremariam, both of whom are understood to be supportive of the move, said an executive privy to the development. He said Air India's board-appointed nomination and remuneration committee (NRC) must approve any such appointment. The 3-member NRC comprises Chandrasekaran, and two independent directors of Air India, Alice Vaidyan and P. R. Ramesh.

Air India management held preliminary talks with Tata Sons' Chandrasekaran and Air India CEO Gebremariam

Emails sent to Air India and Singapore Airlines on 27 October remained unanswered.

Singapore Airlines has been deepening its involvement in Air India by bringing in executives with experience in its own operations, particularly in technical and operational roles. A CFO appointment would extend that influence to the airline's financial management at a time when its losses have more than doubled, said a second executive.

Air India Group reported a consolidated net loss of ₹22,238 crore in fiscal year 2026 (FY26), compared with ₹10,859 crore in FY25. The airline continues to require substantial capital to fund its operations, fleet expansion and transformation, raising questions about the scale and sustainability of financial support from its shareholders.

Singapore Airlines is currently represented on Air India's board by its chief executive, Goh Choon Phong. Two other executives with Singapore Airlines backgrounds: chief operating officer Basil Kwauk and head of engineering and maintenance Jeremy Yew Jin Kit, are part of Air India's 10-member executive leadership team.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Brahamastra, a Lord's Mark venture, takes defence innovation global

Lord's Mark Industries Limited is advancing India's indigenous defence technology through Brahamastra Defence Techno Products Limited. Three years ago, Lord's Mark's passion for technology and commitment to Make in India, set this journey in motion—one that focuses on developing world-class products that showcase Indian engineering globally. The initiative reflects an ambition to build specialised capabilities at home and establish an international position for Indian-developed defence technologies.

Brahamastra's flagship portfolio features three products: *BRAK RT*, a long-range laser rangefinder with a day-channel camera; *BRAK Alpha*, a multi-purpose laser rangefinder; and *TRC-1*, a smart trail camera. They are positioned as having no equivalents worldwide. The wider portfolio includes holographic and reflex sights, telescopic and thermal imaging sights, handheld thermal imagers, day/night surveillance systems, anti-drone systems and other optoelectronic equipment—all supporting Atmanirbhar Bharat.

BRAK RT combines laser-based distance measurement with a day-observation camera. Its stated specifications include a maximum range of 20,000 metres, accuracy of up to one metre (1σ), and a detection of up to five targets. Integrated GPS and orientation sensors provide positional and directional information, while its IP68-rated construction is designed for demanding environments.

BRAK Alpha combines distance measurement with target detection and orientation data. It offers a stated range of 10–5,000 metres, an accuracy of up to 0.5 metres (1σ), and a detection of up to five targets, including a GPS, azimuth measurement and inclination sensing support for field use.

TRC-1, a Smart Trail Camera, provides motion-triggered imaging and day-and-night capture for field surveillance. Its specifications include 5 MP or higher still images, a 1080p video, a minimum of 120-degree field of view and invisible infrared illumination up to 10 metres. Developed in Navi Mumbai, it features role-based permissions and audit records. The video is intended to remain on the camera rather than being centrally stored.

mint Brand Studio
Lord's Mark

The portfolio is being developed amidst the demand for advanced electro-optical, infrared and surveillance technologies. *MarketsandMarkets* projects India's military electro-optics and infrared (EO/IR) market to grow from $1.19 billion in 2026 to $1.78 billion by 2030, at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 10.4%. Globally, *Mordor Intelligence* projects the military electro-optical and infrared systems market to rise from $9.09 billion in 2025 to $10.77 billion by 2031, at a CAGR of 2.87%. These trends could create opportunities for partnerships, deployment and exports, subject to technical, regulatory and procurement requirements.

Sachidanand Upadhyay, founder, MD & CEO of Lord's Mark Industries Limited said, "Our love and enthusiasm for technology and belief in Make in India inspired this journey three years ago. We saw an opportunity to use India's engineering talent and research capabilities to develop world-class indigenous defence technologies for global markets. Our ambition is to go beyond domestic needs and create products reflecting India's technological strength internationally. Brahamastra's portfolio can open new markets and strengthen India's role in specialised defence technology."

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Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd.

Publication of EOI notice

Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Ltd. (ONGC), a Government of India "MAHARATNA" Enterprise, invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from experienced agencies for comprehensive Operation and Maintenance (O&M) of Drillmec make New Generation Drilling Rigs (NG/HP-2000 and NG-1500 categories). The EOI aims to assess market capability, technical expertise, manpower availability, maintenance systems, contracting models, mobilisation timelines and indicative commercial approach, for safe and reliable 24x7 rig operations.

Detailed information regarding the EOI is available on the ONGC Tender Portal https://tenders.ongc.co.in. The last date for submission of EOI responses is 23.11.2026. Interested vendors may submit their responses in electronic format to ts_support@ongc.co.in.

Corrigenda, addenda, amendments, and time extensions to the EOI (if any) will be published only on the ONGC tender portal only. No separate notification shall be issued in the press. Prospective participants are advised to visit the portal regularly for updates.

For further details, please visit ONGC e-portal: https://tenders.ongc.co.in

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NIB No. :- RSGSM/ENA/RC/2026-27/Pur/23 Dated :- 31/10/2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

Bids for ENA are invited from interested bidders up to 6.00 p.m. of 23.11.2026. Other particulars of the bid may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in) of the state; http://excise.rajasthan.gov.in/, departmental website.
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THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.

Hotels, developers sign up 10,000 rooms in October

Varuni Khosla
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Indians travelling within the nation are behind the rush. MINT

Hotel chains and property developers have signed up as many as 10,000 rooms across India in October, and most of them are not in the big cities, according to *Mint* data. Three listed companies, Indian Hotels Co. (IHCL), Lemon Tree Hotels and Brigade Group, account for more than 7,000 of those rooms.

Hotel signings are agreements under which property owners appoint hotel chains to operate or franchise their properties under an established brand. The deals are aimed at smaller cities, airport districts and pilgrimage towns, where chains see their next stretch of growth.

But a signed deal is not a hotel you can book. An expert at HVS Anarock consultancy said that a new hotel typically takes three to five years to open.

The biggest single deal is Lemon Tree's tie-up with developer Omaxe, under which it will run about 4,000 rooms. IHCL, which owns the Taj brand, signed eight hotels with over 2,000 rooms with Adani Airport Holdings.

Hotel chains and property developers have signed up as many as 10,000 rooms across India in October

"Branded hotel room penetration is still exceptionally low for an economy of India's size, and hotel capacity needs to develop alongside the airports, expressways, business districts and tourism infrastructure being created across the country," said Mandeep S. Lamba, president and chief executive officer (South Asia) at HVS Anarock.

The IHCL-Adani agreement, spans eight hotels across Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Lucknow and Guwahati. Adani will develop the hotels, while IHCL will operate them. IHCL also signed three Gateway hotels in October, adding 569 rooms to its room pipeline.

Lemon Tree's agreement with Omaxe, announced on 16 October, is its largest single operating arrangement to date. Once operational, Carnation Hotels—its management arm—will operate around 4,000 rooms across eight locations.

"More recently, hotel companies have been signing at least three to four hotel deals with the same promoters and developers. This helps the hotel management companies as the development risks are increasingly being taken by large real estate and corporate groups," said Rattan Keswani, independent hospitality consultant.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Flipkart looks to expand FPO tie-ups to scale fresh produce

Closer links with farmers and better demand planning can help Flipkart scale fresh produce

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Flipkart works with 25 FPOs and more than 7,000 farmers directly across India. MINT

Flipkart is betting that closer links with farmers and better demand planning can help it scale one of quick commerce's most operationally challenging categories: fresh produce.

The e-commerce company is deepening partnerships with farmers and farmer producer organizations (FPOs), while investing in sourcing infrastructure and demand planning to reduce wastage on its quick-commerce platform Minutes. It also sees scope to expand premium offerings and introduce private labels, Kunal Gupta, senior vice-president of Flipkart and head of Flipkart Minutes, told *Mint*.

"Our focus is on being closer to agricultural production centres so that we can source the freshest produce," Gupta said.

Flipkart works with 25 FPOs and more than 7,000 farmers directly across India. In Pune, one of Minutes' key markets, around 90% of its fruits and vegetables (FnV) procurement comes directly from farmers and farmer partners, Gupta said.

Fresh produce offers margins of 20-40%, depending on the item, according to Satish Meena, analyst at market research firm Datum Intelligence. Leafy vegetables and exotic fruits tend to command higher margins, while staples such as onions and tomatoes are at the lower end. But unsold inventory can quickly turn into wastage, and maintaining consistent quality across batches remains a challenge.

"There is a massive opportunity in the category, but the key is to manage wastage and ensure consistent quality," Meena said.

The push comes amid intensifying competition in India's quick-commerce market, with platforms looking beyond metro cities for growth. According to Datum Intelligence, Blinkit led the market by order volume in September with a 40.2% share, followed by Zepto at 23.3% and Swiggy Instamart at 13.6%. Flipkart Minutes had an 11% share, ahead of Amazon Now (7.4%) and Tata-owned BigBasket (4.6%).

Flipkart's strategy centres on connecting farmers with organised retail demand through local sourcing partners. Its partnership with Agromol Ventures, which works with farmers around Pune, illustrates the model.

Agromol collects produce from nearby villages and handles sorting, grading, quality checks and packing before dispatching it to Minutes' fulfilment centres. Its six facilities across Maharashtra also have temperature-controlled storage rooms maintained at 2-10 degree Celsius.

Flipkart currently has around 37 exclusive collection centres across the country, Gupta said. While it will invest in more facilities where required, exclusivity is not a priority.

"We share demand projections and planning requirements with our partners who work closely with farmers to ensure they have better visibility into market demand, including the quantities and pack sizes of vegetables required. We can make this happen even without exclusive partners," Gupta said.

Produce is checked at collection and fulfilment centres for size, colour and freshness, with items failing to meet specifications rejected. Flipkart aims to receive produce within 60-90 minutes of harvest, he added.

The model also requires farmers to shift towards demand-led cultivation rather than growing produce first and subsequently looking for buyers. Agromol chief executive Amol Ghenand told *Mint* that farmers are trained in practices such as integrated pest and nutrient management.

"We have been working with farmers for the last two years to help improve the quality of their produce and reduce wastage. There is still a long way to go in minimising wastage and improving produce quality across the supply chain, particularly in a year when the country has seen drought conditions," Ghenand said.

However, competing online platforms follow similar sourcing models, making fresh produce difficult to differentiate, Meena said.

Flipkart is also looking beyond conventional fruits and vegetables to higher-value and organic offerings. Gupta said organic products are growing faster than the broader FnV category on the platform, although from a smaller base. He estimated that the overall category was growing at around three times, compared with 10 times for organic produce.

The reporter was at Flipkart's facilities near Pune for reporting at the invitation of the company.

PRODUCE PUSH

THE e-commerce company is deepening partnerships with farmers and FPOs

IT is investing in sourcing infra and demand planning to reduce wastage on Minutes

THE firm also sees scope to expand premium offerings and introduce private labels

IN Pune, around 90% of the firm's FnV procurement comes from farmers and farmer partners

Centre has challenged Delhi High Court's 1 July order. PTI

Centre moves SC on Vedanta's Ravva field award

Krishna Yadav
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NEW DELHI

The Union government has approached the Supreme Court, challenging a Delhi High Court order that allowed Vedanta Ltd and Ravva Oil (Singapore) Pvt. Ltd to enforce foreign arbitration awards arising from a dispute over the Ravva oilfield, involving claims of $99 million.

According to the Supreme Court's cause list, a bench of Justices J.B. Pardiwala and Manmohan will hear the Centre's plea on Monday.

The Centre has challenged the Delhi High Court's 1 July 2026 judgement that rejected its objections to the enforcement of the awards. The high court also directed that bank guarantees furnished by Vedanta and Ravva Oil be released within eight weeks.

The dispute dates back to 1994, when the government entered into a production-sharing contract (PSC) with a consortium comprising Oil and Natural Gas Corp. (ONGC), Videocon Petroleum, Ravva Oil and Cairn Energy to develop the Ravva oilfield in the Krishna-Godavari basin. Cairn Energy's interest in the project subsequently passed to Cairn India, which was later merged with Vedanta.

At the heart of the dispute was how payments made by the companies towards ONGC's historical costs should be accounted for while calculating the parties' respective shares of revenue from oil production. The issue came to be known as the ONGC Carry issue.

Rejecting the government's objections, the Delhi High Court held that an enforcement court could not reopen the merits of the dispute or reconsider the tribunal's findings merely because the government disagreed with them. It dismissed the Centre's objections and allowed the companies' plea, directing that their bank guarantees be released within eight weeks.

The Ravva dispute is not the only legal battle involving Vedanta's oil and gas business. In a separate dispute concerning the CB-OS/2 offshore block in Gujarat's Cambay Basin, the company is challenging the Centre's decision not to extend its contract for another 10 years and to hand over operations to ONGC.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Anthropic IPO gets Indian HNIs excited

FROM PAGE 1

One, before closing 10% above its offer price. The blockbuster IPO made its founder Elon Musk the world's first dollar trillionaire, as his net worth briefly crossed the $1 trillion milestone. After scaling 67% above IPO price, the stock has since seen a volatile pullback, closing just below its IPO price of $135 a share on Friday.

The IPO is expected to raise $100 billion and value Anthropic at up to $1.5 trillion, but intense demand is expected to limit share allocations through established channels and bulge bracket market makers. What makes it even more difficult for Indian investors is that India is not included in the international portion of the offering which includes the likes of Australia, Canada, certain member states of the European Economic Area, Japan, Switzerland and the United Kingdom.

"Realistically, getting shares through the IPO is off the table for any Indian client," a second wealth manager working at an exchange-listed company said. "But interest is unusually high, so we are suggesting participation after the IPO through direct exchange offerings like the liquid stock, exchange-traded funds, or proxy plays like Amazon, Google, TSMC and Samsung."

The IPO is expected to value Anthropic at up to $1.5 trillion. REUTERS

Indirect exposure through major Anthropic's investors like Amazon.com Inc. and Google maker Alphabet Inc., as well as through companies in Anthropic's semiconductor supply chain like Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. and Samsung Electronics Co. is not an isolated strategy.

Wealth managers are fielding inquiries from tech founders, family offices, and business execs across the nation

Bloomberg had reported on 28 October that Asian investors interested in Anthropic's IPO were looking at the company's listed shareholders, crypto derivatives offering exposure and semiconductor stocks related to the firm in order to participate in a potential high-pop stock listing.

The closest Indian parallels to Anthropic and OpenAI are a handful of government-funded startups—Soket AI, BharatGen, a non-profit entity incubated at IIT Bombay, and others—that are still in their early stages. Only Sarvam AI, which has reached a valuation of $1 billion or more, has launched a consumer-facing product. None has unveiled enterprise offerings yet. Two other entities worth noting are publicly listed Fractal Analytics and Sharad Sanghi-backed Neysa AI, which operate in AI infrastructure and enterprise AI, respectively. However, neither is a pure-play generative AI model builder.

"For clients who are showing interest, we are advising them to avoid secondary market investments in Anthropic right now," said a wealth manager handling clients in Bengaluru and Gurugram. "Participating through listed proxy vehicles is currently the most mainstream and best approach."

However, in India, cross-border transfers operate under the Reserve Bank of India's Liberalized Remittance Scheme limit of $250,000 per person annually, and this might make any attempts to take a large exposure to US late-stage high-value startup space difficult.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Imports, low base power best Oct GST growth in four years

FROM PAGE 1

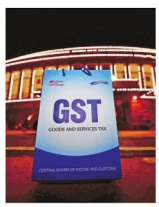
revenue. Total refunds increased a more modest 6.5% to ₹27,934 crore.

Domestic refunds rose 9.8% to ₹14,007 crore, while export-related refunds processed through ICEGATE increased 3.4% to ₹13,927 crore. Net domestic revenue grew 16.4% to ₹1.45 trillion, while net customs revenue jumped 56.2% to ₹58,319 crore.

Nitin Vijaivergia, partner at Price Waterhouse & Co LLP, said October's GST collections reflected "strong revenue momentum". While domestic collections grew 15.8%, import revenues surged 42.2%, highlighting the growing contribution of imports to overall GST revenue. He said the trend merited attention from a domestic manufacturing perspective.

The cumulative collections for April-October indicated that revenue buoyancy extended beyond a single month, he added.

Experts said the sustained growth in import-linked collections highlights the need to strengthen domestic manufacturing capabilities.



Net GST collections, after refunds, rose 25.6% on-year. PTI

While the production-linked incentive (PLI) schemes have delivered encouraging results in select sectors, the government may need to revisit and recalibrate schemes in sectors with unutilised budgets to better support the broader objective of an Atmanirbhar Bharat, they said.

"The GST collections for October 2026 reflect the continued resilience of the Indian economy, despite persistent global headwinds. The steady month-on-month rise in revenue indicates strong underlying consumption and improving compliance," said Saurabh Agarwal, tax partner at EY India.

"The festive season should keep demand buoyant, and collections for the coming month are likely to remain strong. Businesses should use this period to keep their compliance and reconciliation processes robust, so that the benefits of this growth are sustained," Agarwal said.

The latest collections come amid a broader push to reform the GST framework.

M.S. Mani, partner at Deloitte India, said sustained revenue buoyancy, despite the rate cuts introduced last year, was giving the GST Council the confidence and headroom to advance reforms focused on faster refunds, smoother credit flows and reducing compliance friction for businesses.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

E-motorcycles threaten to disrupt Bajaj, TVS' presence in Africa

FROM PAGE 1

cycle market followed by Japanese players like Honda, Yamaha and others.

The shift could have implications for India's two-wheeler exporters, which have built a sizeable business in Africa but are yet to establish a presence in the electric motorcycle segment. With commercial riders accounting for a large part of the market, the contest will depend not just on the cost and performance of electric bikes but also on the availability of battery-swapping infrastructure.

Initially relying on product and technology supplies from Chinese two-wheeler manufacturer Horwin, Spiro has now entered into a strategic partnership with Chinese electric two-wheeler maker Yadea. It operates across Kenya, Uganda, Rwanda, Nigeria, Benin, Togo and Cameroon.

The company is targeting the same motorcycle-taxi operators who have traditionally relied on models such as the Bajaj Boxer and TVS HLX. Known as boda boda riders in East Africa, these commercial users are increasingly being offered electric alternatives.

Spiro assembles motorcycles in Africa using Chinese kits and components while building a battery-swapping network to support their use.

"In Rwanda, in less than 24 months, 40% of the entire stock of bikes is electric now. Every month, 85% of the bikes sold are electric, and of that 85%, over 90% is Spiro," Gupta said in an interview with *Mint*.

"You can see something similar in Uganda where between 35 to 50% of the bikes on a month-on-month being sold are electric," he added.

The International Energy Agency's Global EV Outlook 2026 estimates that electric two-wheeler sales in Africa reached around 70,000 in 2025. Uganda accounted for more than 30,000, while Kenya crossed 25,000, with electric motorcycles making up around 15% of new registrations.

MotorCyclesData says Africa is leading global regions in electric motorcycle sales growth this year, with volumes rising 86.9% through September. Estimates of total volumes for 2026 are not available, with data on the continent's two-wheeler market remaining limited.

India's two-wheeler exporters built a sizeable business in Africa but are yet to establish a presence in e-motorcycles. BLOOMBERG

Spiro expects its monthly sales to rise to 50,000-60,000 next year from around 17,000 currently, Gupta said. The company is investing around $70 million in factories in Kenya, Nigeria and the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), and plans to source about 85% of its components locally.

Its annual production capacity is expected to reach 600,000 motorcycles by June-July 2027. Spiro plans to expand to around 20 markets, with the DRC, Malawi, Mali and Ethiopia among its next targets. It entered Ghana earlier in October.

The shift has implications for India's two largest two-wheeler exporters. TVS said in February that Africa accounts for nearly 70% of its export volumes and more than half of its global operational revenue. Analyst estimates suggest that about a third of Bajaj's exports go to the continent.

While Spiro's current sales remain smaller than the combined volumes of the Indian manufacturers in Africa, the growing electric motorcycle market means a rising share of incremental sales is coming from a segment in which Bajaj and TVS are not yet active.

Both companies have established electric vehicle businesses in India, led by scooters. Bajaj has said its first electric motorcycle is expected in FY28, with export markets likely to be its initial focus.

Around 75-80% of Spiro's customers use motorcycles for commercial purposes, mainly as motorcycle taxis, Gupta said.

Spiro says it has deployed more than 100,000 electric motorcycles and built over 2,500 battery-swapping stations across seven markets.

Founded in 2019 as M Auto Electric and rebranded as Spiro in 2022, the company closed a $270 million funding round in June 2026, including $55 million from Chinese fund NewTrails Capital. Its other backers include Impact Fund Denmark, Equitane, Nithio and Africa Go Green Fund.

Spiro remains small compared with Bajaj and TVS, which have decades of experience, Gupta said.

He believes the market can support several players as Bajaj and TVS prepare to enter the electric motorcycle segment.

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Insurers want Irdai expense caps linked to business size

Insurers proposed the change in feedback to Irdai's 23 September consultation paper

Anshika Kayastha & Samriddhi Mahar
MUMBAI

Insurers have urged the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) to adopt scale-based regulations, arguing that uniform expense limits could disadvantage smaller and newer players as the regulator moves to tighten controls on operating costs and distribution commissions.

The proposal was among the key suggestions in insurers' feedback to Irdai's 23 September consultation paper on distribution commissions. A scale-based framework, industry executives say, would bridge the gap between the regulator's proposals and what the industry believes is practically achievable, four industry executives told *Mint*. Saturday was the deadline for submitting feedback.

"The logic is that some fixed costs will always be fixed. So, if your scale is substantially smaller or lesser than somebody else's, those fixed expenses in percentage terms will be very very high," one of the senior executives cited above said, adding that insurers want that a "differentiator" be created.

The consultation paper proposes an overhaul of insurance business models and distributor commissions, alongside sharp reductions in insurers' expenses of management (EoM), which measure operating expenses as a percentage of premiums.

Smaller and newer insurers typically have higher EoMs because of investments in expansion, distribution and innovation, coupled with a lower premium base.

Larger insurers, by contrast, benefit from scale efficiencies that allow them to report lower EoMs even when their absolute expenses are higher.

Industry participants fear that meeting the proposed limits within the prescribed timeline could force mid-sized and smaller insurers to curtail or defer growth investments, creating an uneven playing field.

The consultation paper proposes an overhaul of insurance business models and distributor commissions, alongside sharp reductions in insurers' EoM. ISTOCKPHOTO

Tighter commission economics could also constrain newer insurers' ability to use bancassurance and lending partnerships, putting them at a relative disadvantage, said Ashish Modani, senior vice president and group head at Icra Ltd.

"A scale- or maturity-based regulatory framework could distinguish established insurers based on market share, AUM/premium, operating vintage and/or distribution reach," Modani said, adding that a differentiated regulatory framework would help balance regulatory safeguards with the need for newer insurers to build scale and distribution.

SCALE DIVIDE

SMALLER insurers have higher EoMs due to expansion costs and lower premium bases	**SCALE** efficiencies help larger insurers keep EoMs lower despite higher expenses	**INSURERS** seek classification based on premium income and business type	**SMALLER** insurers may struggle to sustain business without such flexibility

The framework insurers are proposing would use a principle-driven, tiered approach to determine regulatory supervision, compliance and capital requirements based on an insurer's size and assets under management, complexity, policy volumes, systemic importance and risk profile.

Insurers have also suggested classifying companies by overall premium income for life insurers and gross direct premium income for general insurers.

The differentiation, however, would not extend to commissions themselves.

"The commissions will remain unchanged. Whether you are the biggest company or the smallest company, you will pay only the commission which has been decided by the regulator. But there will be some more flexibility for other expenses," a second executive said.

Without such flexibility, smaller insurers could find it harder to make their business economics work, potentially leading to consolidation, the executive added.

The idea has precedents elsewhere in financial services. In 2022, the Reserve Bank of India introduced a scale-based regulatory framework for non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), classifying them into four categories: base layer, middle layer, upper layer and top layer.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has also introduced scale-based regulations for mutual funds, effective 1 April 2026. Under the framework, compliance requirements, asset thresholds and expense ratios for asset management firms are determined by their scale, corpus size, investor concentration and category mandates.

"That formula (scale-based regulations) has worked in mutual funds. If it has worked, why don't we take the best of it and adapt it to ours instead of trying to reinvent it," said Sumit Rai, managing director and chief executive officer of Edelweiss Life Insurance.

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Apax sees India's AI edge driving future investments

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Harjot Dhaliwal, partner and India head for Apax, with Mitch Truwit, co-chief executive of Apax Partners.

India's technological capabilities, education levels and intellectual capital will ensure it does not fall behind in the artificial intelligence (AI) race, said Mitch Truwit, co-chief executive of global private equity firm Apax Partners. In India to mark two decades of investing in the country, Truwit said the firm expects to step up its investment pace in the Indian market going forward.

"India may not be pioneers in LLMs and the rest of it. But if you look at what the challenge is for most businesses out there, the challenge is how do you operationalize AI in a way that creates efficiency. What I think India is quite good at is change management, which most companies are not," Truwit said in an exclusive interaction with *Mint*.

"I believe that, given India's capabilities in technology, and the need for change, and the ability, the brain power of the people and the education levels, that's something that these companies can help effectuate change on," he added.

Apax Partners has invested $4 billion in the Indian market and has returned more than $10 billion to investors

The firm, which has backed companies such as Fractal Analytics, Globalogic and Healthium in the past, considers India as one of its best-performing markets. "If you look at our historic returns here, they have been exceptional. We've delivered $10 billion of value for investors, north of 25% IRR (internal rate of return). That's proven to be a really good market," Truwit said.

At a time when many foreign portfolio investors have pulled money out of India over the past 12-18 months, long-term investors such as private equity and buyout funds have been raising their bets in the country. "India's GDP is growing at 7 or 8%, not 15%, or when there's you know obviously inflation and things like that and currency issues, it looks riskier, right? And that's true, but we're patient capital, and I think there's an opportunity here," Truwit added.

Despite the currency depreciation, India continues to be an attractive market for long-term investors such as Apax Partners. "I think some of this kind of short-term headwinds that we're seeing, whether it's because of geo-politics, oil prices, or the froth in the AI market, it's a different lens for public market investors. But when you take a five-seven-year view, and most investments, it's not a straight line. But like Mitch already said, we really want to focus on how we can continue to drive operational improvement and growth in the businesses, and some of these things are outside of our control. But we obviously, when we underwrite the deals, bake it in. This is the historical currency depreciation. How do we bake into our returns and cost of capital effectively," said Harjot Dhaliwal, partner and India head for Apax. Apax has so far invested around $4 billion in India and returned over $10 billion to investors. Unlike most of its global peers that have an Asia fund to invest out of, Apax has just one pool of capital that it deploys globally. Currently, it is investing out of its eleventh fund of $12 billion. The firm is targeting a first close by March for its new twelfth fund, news reports said.

It might invest around 10% of the new capital into India going forward. It will put this capital behind technology, consumer, and healthcare businesses, Truwit said.

Currently, exposure to India is under 10% of the firm's total investments.

"Supply chain management, cybersecurity and new age digital businesses are very attractive where we feel we can help them grow and maximize value," she said.

Asked why Apax has been slower to deploy capital in India than its more active peers, Truwit said the firm does not allocate separate pools of capital to Asia and the US.

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Extract of unaudited Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter ended September 30, 2026

(₹ in Million)

S. No	Particulars	Quarter ended September 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	Year Ended March 31, 2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended September 30, 2025 (Unaudited)
1	Total income from operations	3,115.94	11,360.03	2,761.32
2	Net Profit for the period (before tax and Exceptional items)	654.07	2,611.64	617.14
3	Net Profit for the period before tax (after Exceptional items)	654.07	2,611.64	617.14
4	Net Profit for the period after tax attributable to Owners (after Exceptional items)	486.08	1,981.22	443.93
5	Total Comprehensive Income for the period attributable to Owners [Comprising Profit for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	552.52	2,381.66	581.65
6	Equity share capital (Face Value of ₹ 1/- each)	207.08	206.92	206.60
7	Earnings per Share: (Face Value of ₹ 1/- each)			
	1. Basic : (Not annualised)	2.35	9.59	2.15
	2. Diluted : (Not annualised)	2.35	9.56	2.14

Additional information on Standalone financial results is as follows:

(₹ in Million)

S. No	Particulars	Quarter ended September 30, 2026 (Unaudited)	Year Ended March 31, 2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended September 30, 2025 (Unaudited)
1	Total income from operations	1,264.68	4,708.59	1,140.82
2	Profit before tax	409.32	1,711.79	395.90
3	Profit/(Loss) after tax	300.23	1,294.50	295.65

Notes:

1. The above is extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Financials Results filed with the Stock Exchange under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligation and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015. The full format of the Quarterly Financials Results are available on the Company's website at www.latentview.com and the Stock Exchange website at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com
2. The above results were reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee at the meeting held on 31 October, 2026 and approved by the Board of Directors at their meeting held on 31 October, 2026

For Latent View Analytics Limited
Sonal Ramrakhiani
Chief Executive Officer

Place: Chennai
Date: 31 October,2026

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Behind the scenes of crypto's biggest nightmare: a record-breaking cyber heist

'No crypto wallet is 100% safe,' Binance's founder had warned a week earlier

Sam Kessler, Angus Berwick & Caitlin Ostroff

Last week, the founder of the world's largest crypto exchange delivered a chilling warning that read more like a tagline to a horror movie than a reminder to be vigilant on cybersecurity.

"No crypto wallet is 100% safe," Binance's Changpeng Zhao wrote on X, the social-media platform. "No tech is 100% secure."

Binance's own users were soon caught in a whirlwind of recent software hacks, widespread panic and bitter recriminations. In the latest, and biggest, cyberattack that has buffeted the world this " Black October ," North Korean hackers ransacked Binance on Thursday afternoon. In 20 minutes, they had made off with at least $6.3 billion .

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The speed, scale and sophistication of the heist has left the crypto industry reeling, and renewed questions about the digital-asset markets and whether they will ever fulfill their promise as a viable alternative to the traditional financial system or even a safe place to store money. The momentum that had lifted bitcoin and other cryptocurrencies to record highs last year had already stalled. But the recent spate of attacks, punctuated by Binance's hit, threatens to deal a more serious blow.

"It's a really tough moment for the crypto industry," said Ari Redbord, global head of policy at crypto intelligence firm TRM Labs.

And for Binance and its customers, the moment arrived like a jump scare.

No warning

Around 11:20 p.m. in Abu Dhabi, home to Binance offices (4:20 p.m. in New York), the company's cybersecurity team detected a breach—more than $1 billion had been siphoned from the exchange, seemingly out of the blue. The group alerted the exchange's top executives, who convened a crisis team of some 100 employees. Within minutes, the staff were on a conference call. Every single senior executive had signed on.

The team could only watch in horror as money streamed out of Binance's accounts, in real time. An initial tally of the stolen funds placed it at $1 billion; a massive heist, to be sure, but not a record.

But the figure kept rising—and rising. It reached $3 billion, then by 4:40 p.m., doubled to more than $6 billion.

Alarm bells soon began to sound across the industry. Security firms that monitor activity on blockchains, the digital ledgers where crypto transactions are recorded, had also spotted the anomaly at Binance. Those firms' automatic alerts began to flood the offices of their clients, many of the world's biggest crypto investors.

The company's cyber investigators began to work with their own partners that specialize in tracing cryptocurrency—TRM Labs, Chainalysis and Elliptic—to compile a list of digital addresses containing the pilfered funds.

Binance's next move was to reach out to the issuers of the stablecoins that function as digital dollars that move between crypto wallets. Because these firms, including Tether and Circle, can freeze their coins in place and blacklist suspicious wallets, their rapid cooperation can be the key to stemming the flow of stolen money before it can be laundered.

By then, though, the wider crypto world began to notice Binance was suddenly missing billions of dollars. "Unconfirmed, but possibly massive binance hack," one X user with the handle "Spreek" wrote at 4:32 p.m. New York time.

Changpeng Zhao, Binance founder and CEO REUTERS

Thirteen minutes later, Zach Witkoff's mobile phone buzzed a disturbing call from his chief technology officer: He, too, had spotted something wrong at Binance.

Hallmarks of a Hack

"This had all the hallmarks of a hack," said Witkoff, who founded World Liberty Financial, a crypto firm, with President Trump and his sons in the lead up to the 2024 election. After taking office, Trump pardoned Zhao , who pleaded guilty in 2023 to violating U.S. anti-money-laundering requirements.

Witkoff noticed that Binance's hackers had received funds from Tornado Cash—a "mixer" program often used by bad actors to obfuscate the source of their funds. "This was so obviously a hack that someone who is a novice in blockchain analytics would know."

Binance confirmed to Witkoff that it had suffered a breach and gave him a list of hack-linked addresses. Witkoff worked with the company that issues USDI, World Liberty Financial's stablecoin, to freeze some $27 million in stolen assets.

After World Liberty implemented its first freeze—blacklisting an address that held some of the company's WLFI tokens—Tether and Circle, the largest stablecoin companies, soon followed suit.

While their cooperation helped stop some funds from escaping, Binance was still in a race to find and then freeze billions more. They would soon learn they didn't get there fast enough.

The company's top executives, including Yi He , Binance's co-CEO and Zhao's romantic partner, had spent the evening and early-morning hours on the phone calls with industry partners. Yi, who is based in the U.A.E. and seven and a half months pregnant, didn't sleep the entire night. Richard Teng , Yi's co-CEO, stayed up all night in Hong Kong.

But as they continued to scour the blockchains for missing funds, the hackers had been busy, too.

At 5 p.m. ET, the hackers placed $60 million worth of stablecoins into a crypto-lending platform called Aave. The coins served as collateral the hackers used to borrow almost 20,000 ether, worth about $44.6 million at the time.

Ether and other assets like bitcoin can't be frozen, so the transaction essentially moved the money beyond the outer limits of any centralized platform's control. Meaning, the hackers were home free.

Decentralized platforms like Aave eventually shut down loans to those suspicious accounts, but the hackers ultimately escaped with some $2.4 billion in un-freezable crypto assets, according to TRM.

By 5:15 p.m., the social-media outcry on Binance's crisis had grown too loud for the company and its founder to ignore.

Funds are safe

"It does look like a hack on Binance," Zhao wrote on X. "User funds are safe!"

In his initial X post, Zhao said $1.7 billion had been frozen so far. Thirty minutes later, Binance delivered its own statement on the incident, writing on X that it was aware of "a potential security issue" and would be pausing all withdrawals until it was resolved.

> Binance contacted issuers of stablecoins, which act as digital dollars transferred between crypto

The withdrawal pause sparked a new wave of panic on social media—with some on X remarking that it reminded them of the collapse of FTX, Sam Bankman-Fried 's crypto exchange, which famously paused withdrawals ahead of its precipitous collapse . Throughout the evening, Binance insisted that all user funds were safe.

At 10:25 p.m., Binance said $3 billion had been frozen in connection to what it had continued referring to as a "security incident." The company said an initial investigation indicated that a DevOps engineer's laptop had been compromised, allowing an attacker to make unauthorized withdrawals from Binance. (The company said later that other company infrastructure may have been compromised as well).

The company also gave its first official estimate of the total monetary impact: $6.3 billion.

At 10:30 p.m., *The Wall Street* Journal reported findings from cybersecurity research firms TRM Labs and Pangolin Intelligence that the attack was linked to North Korea's state-sponsored Trader-Traitor hacking unit. The same group has been behind many of the largest crypto attacks, including the $1.5 billion ByBit attack in 2025, previously the largest hack in crypto history.

Not now, Elon

Crypto has long been a favored target of sophisticated hackers, but the pace and severity has worsened this year. Suspected North Korea-linked hackers were responsible for nearly 89% of reported crypto hack losses so far this year, according to Chainalysis .

In an earlier exchange on X, a user argued the losses represented just 0.69% of Binance's total assets. "Loss might be a bit higher than that, but will cover," Zhao replied.

Then, as if the billionaire's night weren't bad enough, he heard from Elon Musk .

An X user had replied to a post from Zhao reassuring users that Binance would cover user losses with a screenshot of a similar statement from Bankman-Fried, the infamous entrepreneur and once Zhao's rival. Musk responded with a grimace emoji.

Five hours later, Zhao responded.

"Elon, have a lot of respect for you, but bad time to troll," he wrote. "Please stop."

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Russia's shadow fleet turns to nets and rubber tires for makeshift drone armor

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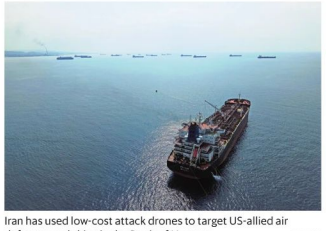
Istanbul—Russia's shadow fleet of oil tankers is decking itself out in netting, metal cages and other tools to protect against a wave of Ukrainian drone strikes on the energy exports that are proving such a vital economic lifeline for the Kremlin.

Nearly every day since August, Russian oil tankers have emerged from the Black Sea here in Istanbul, sailing down the Bosporus displaying nets, cages, rubber tires and other antidrone devices.

These protective layers resemble the vast webs of netting draped across buildings and roads that are common in front-line cities in Ukraine, where Russian and Ukrainian forces have turned to drones as the primary weapon in the more than four-year-long war.

At least 60 ships draped in countermeasures to ward off drones have been documented transiting the Bosporus since August, according to images of the vessels reviewed by *The Wall Street Journal* and provided by Yoruk Isik, a ship spotter and maritime analyst based in Istanbul. Isik, who leads a consulting firm called Bosphorus Observer, photographed the ships, nearly all of which are under U.S. and other Western sanctions for transporting Russian oil.

Metal casings known as "cope cages" initially emerged as a way for Russian and Ukrainian military vehicles to defend against small drones, particularly first person view drones that are piloted remotely and can slip past more expensive and advanced air-defense systems. The Israeli military has also used them in recent years to defend against FPV drones used by Lebanon's Hezbollah and militants in Gaza .


Iran has used low-cost attack drones to target US-allied air defences and ships in the Strait of Hormuz. REUTERS

"It looks like Kharkiv. It looks like the netting they have on the front line," said Eric Woods, an independent security analyst and longtime Russia observer.

The nets hanging on the Russian oil tankers appear to be a makeshift measure, quickly strung up to protect the most sensitive parts of the ship such as engine components, according to military analysts who reviewed the images for the Journal. Another technique is to hang rubber tires from the deck to protect the engine and rudder, a crude way of stopping a drone from crashing into a ship and disabling it.

"It's more in-your-face proof that the Russian navy has lost control in the Black Sea," said Isik. "For Russia, earning foreign currency is under great threat."

Hunting down the shadow fleet offers Ukraine a number of strategic advantages in its fight against the Russian invasion. Russian oil tankers are likely to be less well defended than Russian military sites that have already been hardened against drone strikes. Hitting the tankers also adds to Ukraine's broader campaign to pile economic pressure on Russia, in which it has also targeted oil refineries and data centers to hinder its ability to finance the war.

The shadow fleet exposes a specific pressure point on the Russian financial system. The aging tankers operate outside global norms for insuring and regulating shipping, which means they are often insured and underwritten by Russia's state-backed banks.

"They're explicitly trying to put pressure on the Russian banking system and their ability to fund insurance," said Woods.

The commander of Ukraine's drone forces said in September that they had disabled 300 Russian shadow-fleet vessels since July. The number couldn't be independently verified.

Ukraine has long targeted Russia's shadow fleet, but it stepped up attacks in 2025 in an attempt to gain leverage over Russia when the Trump administration was pushing the two countries to negotiate an end to the war. The attacks also turn the tables on Russia after years in which Moscow's forces have targeted Ukraine's energy and other vital infrastructure as a part of a campaign to psychologically wear down the Ukrainian civilian population.

In the past, Ukraine has claimed attacks on Russian tankers using uncrewed sea drones that glide along the water's surface. The shadow fleet's countermeasures are evidence of a shift, showing an effort to defend against medium and long-range aerial FPV drones, military analysts said.

The antidrone nets and cages are a sign of how the Black Sea is becoming an important theater in the war. Russia in recent months has intensified its strikes on Ukraine's grain-exporting ports and ships, while suspected Russian drone attacks are also increasingly threatening NATO members on the Black Sea. Authorities in Romania and Bulgaria have blamed Russia for repeated drone strikes , including those that have sunk ships near their territorial waters.

Ukraine is fighting back, using drone and missile strikes to push Russia's Black Sea fleet farther to the sea's eastern shore. Russian attacks on Ukrainian grain exports have also triggered a spike in the global price of wheat .

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The escalation is further squeezing global energy supply chains, and underscores the threat drones now pose in the wars in Ukraine and the Persian Gulf.

Iran has used its arsenal of low-cost, one-way attack drones to overwhelm air defenses used by the U.S. and its allies, and to target ships in the Strait of Hormuz, contributing to this year's energy supply crisis.

"It's going to be a global trend," said Samuel Bendett, an analyst of military robotics with the security policy institute CNA, referring to the nets and cages. "It's the cheapest and easiest way to protect a ship against UAVs."

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AI investors are racing to get insurance on the biggest market bet in history

Gunjan Banerji
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Wall Street placed a multitrillion-dollar bet on artificial intelligence. Some investors are desperate to take the other side.

The trade has proved a lasting winner up to now. Excitement about AI's potential to transform the economy has lifted stocks from tech heavyweights to utilities and chip makers, while driving a speculative frenzy in other corners of the market.

Some of these optimistic forecasts got a recent reality check, with big and small players alike failing to meet the market's expectations. Now, investors are sizing up how to protect themselves against the risk of a larger unraveling.

"We're seeing really significant demand from folks looking to protect downside," said Stephen Solaka, a senior vice president at Gateway Investment Advisers.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The jitters are starting to show up in a number of ways: the yields lenders demand to finance big data-center projects and chip purchases; the plunging stock and bond prices of some AI "neocloud" companies , such as CoreWeave that are borrowing heavily; and steep sell-offs from tech darlings including Alphabet and Intel , which just recorded some of their biggest one-day drops ever. The tech-heavy Nasdaq lost 2.9% Friday, capping its worst month since March 2025.

Solaka oversees portfolios for individuals who often have concentrated bets in individual stocks, including the tech giants that have powered markets in recent years. Increasingly, he said, his clients—some of whom are former employees of those very technology companies—are looking for something else: insurance.

"These people have made so much money, they're quitting to hedge their stock," Solaka said, adding that some companies have restrictions around employees' trades.

Investors and tech executives alike are turning to options and credit-default swaps for protection.

Put options, which give investors the right to sell stock at a specific price at a future date, are growing in volume. Contracts tied to the neocloud CoreWeave surged to the highest level on record this month and have stayed elevated, Cboe Global Markets data show.

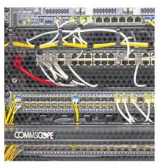
Some of the most popular bets tied to CoreWeave have been put options expiring in 2028, paying out if the shares plunged to $35. The shares hovered at around $55 this week.

Meanwhile, the cost to protect against a debt default in hyperscalers Amazon , Alphabet, Microsoft , Meta and Oracle widened over the past month to the highest levels going back to 2021, according to the bond data provider Solve. "There were no exceptions, suggesting broad market concern about the sector rather than idiosyncratic credit events at individual companies," said Eugene Grinberg, a co-founder of Solve.

The recalibration in Oracle credit-default spreads was especially stark, widening by more than 1 percentage point.

The AI build-out is expected to grow so large that traders are cooking up other ways to hedge its risks.

Quant trading firm Jump Trading recently launched a trading desk for computing power. The nascent operation has been taking advantage of wide price differences across providers, the types of inefficiencies that have been tougher to come by in mainstream markets such as stocks and options. It has also been structuring over-the-counter derivatives, including for those who want to hedge against a big collapse in prices going forward.


Servers inside the JN1 Equinix 4 megawatts capacity data centre in Germiston. AFP

"Folks are becoming more discerning about which participants are winners and losers, and asking tougher questions," said Dave Olsen, president of Jump. "People are drilling deeper into the economic models."

Here's how a trade would work.

A neocloud or AI infrastructure developer that rents out Nvidia chips might buy a put option to hedge against the possibility that the hourly rental rates they pocket will plunge if demand drops.

It would have the right to sell that compute power at a specific price by a stated date, buffering itself from a steeper hit to profits. Jump would agree to take the other side. Jump could also negotiate a cash-settled contract, simply paying the provider in cash. Or the trading firm could agree to rent the compute, or find someone else to rent it to for a profit.

The cost to rent Nvidia B300 chips has surged around 56% this year to $7.56 an hour, according to a Silicon Data index. Jump, for example, could agree to buy if prices fell to $4 an hour.

Olsen and his traders are closely scrutinizing the creditworthiness of those they cut deals with, and the likelihood that they might default on their obligations.

Big exchanges and trading firms are also looking to launch a web of derivatives tied to compute, as it is known in the industry.

Susquehanna International Group, one of the largest trading firms on Wall Street, has fielded interest—both directly and through intermediaries such as brokers—from data centers and privately held neoclouds seeking to hedge their exposure to semiconductor chips, said Nick Volbi, head of institutional prediction markets at the trading firm. If compute prices sank because of decreased demand or increased supply, the trades would pay out, hedging an option buyer against losses in other parts of its business.

That includes put option trades tied to a compute index, which can serve as insurance to assuage lenders at banks, he said.

"I'm going to go to a potential lender and say, 'Hey, if I buy this structure and I get this form of insurance, can you now give me financing? And what would that financing look like?' " Volbi said.

There has been some thin trading in prediction markets tied to data-center moratoriums in certain states. Kalshi offers trades on which states might halt new data-center developments before 2028, including New Hampshire, Michigan and Maine. So far, though, trades have been sparse.

Olsen said hedging strategies as a whole are still dwarfed by the AI trade. Many remain bullish.

"I don't think my house is going to catch on fire, but I still have insurance," Olsen said. "You don't need to be bearish to want some insurance."

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

500
THE NUMBER of Patriot PAC-3 missiles the US approved for sale to Ukraine in an estimated $2.1 billion deal to supply defensive weapons

₹8
HIKE IN price per litre of Nandini milk across all variants from 1 November, prompting Bengaluru Hotels Association to warn restaurant prices may rise, too

90%
THE PERCENTAGE of assets stolen in a record $6.3 billion hack that cryptocurrency exchange Binance has replaced using its own funds

84%
THE PERCENTAGE of Indian millennials using AI-powered tools for shopping, leading adoption ahead of Gen Z consumers, as per McKinsey & Co. report

$700 mn
THE POTENTIAL annual loss Alaska Air Group faces this year amid soaring fuel prices and geopolitical challenges, driving it to cut about 200 non-contract roles

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

OMCs up commercial LPG, jet fuel prices

Effective 1 November, OMCs have raised the price of a 19kg commercial LPG cylinder by ₹10. PTI

India's state-run oil-marketing companies (OMCs) have raised prices of commercial cooking gas and aviation turbine fuel (ATF) amid persistently high international crude oil prices due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia.

Effective 1 November, oil marketing companies have increased the price of a 19kg commercial liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) cylinder by ₹10 to ₹2,820. The price of aviation turbine fuel has also been raised by ₹1.37 per litre to ₹138.50, according to the updated price list of of the government fuel retailers.

The hike in commercial LPG prices comes as restaurants, hotels, catering businesses and food outlets typically see a surge in demand during the festive season.

However, there is no change in the price of domestic LPG, which remains at ₹942 for a 14.2kg cylinder. Petrol and diesel prices have also remained unchanged. This is the third consecutive monthly increase in commercial LPG prices. Rates were raised by ₹9.50 per 19kg cylinder in September and by ₹62.50 in October. The latest increase follows two consecutive monthly reductions of ₹183.50 in July and ₹192 in August. **DHIRENDRA KUMAR**

Former joint drugs controller freed

A special Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) court at Rouse Avenue on Saturday discharged Dr S. Eswara Reddy, former joint drugs controller at the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation, and three others in a 2022 bribery case linked to Biocon Biologics Ltd. Reddy was among the shortlisted contenders for the post of Drugs Controller General of India in 2022. In a 60-page order, the court noted that the allegations failed to raise even mere suspicion, let alone grave suspicion, ruling that CBI could not establish a prima facie case warranting a trial. The accused were discharged under Section 250 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (Section 227 of the Criminal Procedure Code). **PRIYANKA SHARMA**

Aditya Birla Lifestyle Q2 profit doubles

Aditya Birla Lifestyle Brands Ltd has reported a twofold increase in consolidated net profit to ₹53.05 crore for the September quarter of FY27, year-on-year. The company had posted a net profit of ₹23.44 crore during July-September FY26, according to a regulatory filing. Its revenue from operations was up 11.17% to ₹2,265.61 crore in the September quarter of FY27. It was ₹2,037.90 crore in the year-ago period.

This 11% revenue growth marks its "fourth consecutive quarter of double-digit growth", the Aditya Birla Group firm said in its earnings statement. Total expenses of Aditya Birla Lifestyle Brands were at ₹2,225 crore, up 9.71% in the second quarter of FY27. **PTI**

The tenure of the Nandan Nilekani led panel has been extended till January 2027. BLOOMBERG

Centre extends time of exam reform panel

The Centre has extended the tenure of the Nandan Nilekani-led task force working on exam reforms till January 2027, persons aware of the matter said. Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the constitution of the high-powered six-member committee a day after Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation as the Union education minister following massive student protests at Delhi's Jantar Mantar on 25 July.

The task force set up in July received over 50,000 suggestions from students, parents, teachers, academic institutions, subject matter experts, industry organisations and exam-conducting bodies. "The stakeholder consultations have been going on. The government has also submitted an affidavit in the Supreme Court listing the progress made by the panel so far. The panel has now been granted time till January 2027 to submit its report," the source said. The panel's tenure was till October 2027. The panel has also consulted former Isro chairman K. Radhakrishnan, who headed a panel set up by the Centre following the 2024 NEET paper leak. The Radhakrishnan Committee, which was set up in June 2024, submitted its recommendations in October that year. **PTI**

REUTERS

Maruti flags rise in shipping turmoil, but exports unhurt

Maruti's exports rose 59.3% in October, hinting at room for growth once the conflict eases

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India's largest carmaker, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd, has flagged worsening shipping disruptions in West Asia, with even the alternative routes it has been using to export vehicles coming under strain. Yet, demand in the affected markets remains intact, prompting the carmaker to find new channels to reach customers, a senior executive said.

The challenges come even as Maruti's exports jumped 59.3% in October, suggesting room for growth once the conflict eases. "The Middle East situation has actually slightly worsened. We were using an alternate route, even that alternate route has a bit of a problem," Rahul Bharti, senior executive officer for corporate affairs, said at a press conference on Sunday. "So, this number (export growth) is despite the increased challenges in the Middle East. Imagine when the war gets over or when the conflict gets over, where would exports be," he said.

The comments mark the first comment by a senior executive of an Indian automaker on the worsening shipping scenario in West Asia and its implications for vehicle exports. The war broke out late February after a joint US and Israel operation in Iran, which has remained on the boil since, with disruptions on key trade routes such as the Strait of Hormuz.

Maruti exported 49,872 vehicles in October, up 59.3% from a year ago. The carmaker accounts for more than half of India's passenger vehicle exports.

Trade routes passing through the West Asia channels are a key gateway to Europe and North Africa which can be affected if they are disrupted. Carmakers such as Hyundai Motor India, Volkswagen and Nissan, among others, are the major vehicle exporters from their Indian factories.

Two-wheeler manufacturers such as Bajaj Auto, TVS Motor and Hero Motocorp also export to several countries and have faced disruptions in trade routes and rising logistic costs. Owing to logistics hurdles and rising commodity prices due to the West Asia war-led disruptions, Maruti reported a decline of 26% in its profit to ₹2,466 crore, while Hyundai Motor India also saw a 24% decline to ₹1,196 crore in the September quarter.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

IL&FS moves NCLT to recover funds

Infrastructure Leasing & Financial Services (IL&FS) has approached the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) seeking recovery of ₹185.88 crore "excess managerial remuneration" paid to its former directors and those of two group companies following the recasting of financial statements for five financial years, between 2013-14 and 2017-18.

In an application filed before the Mumbai Bench of the NCLT, IL&FS has sought directions to its former directors and two key subsidiaries, IL&FS Financial Services (IFIN) and IL&FS Transportation Networks (ITNL), to return the excess remuneration.

The company has sought an interim direction requiring the identified former directors "to deposit the excess managerial remuneration/undue gains in a separate interest-bearing fixed deposit account", during the pendency of the hearing before NCLT. **PTI**

Passenger vehicle sales in October represent growth of about 13–15% year-on-year. MINT

Domestic PV sales over 500,000 in Oct

Buoyed by robust festive demand, domestic passenger vehicle dispatches breached the record 500,000 mark in October, with leading automakers such as Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai and Mahindra & Mahindra recording their highest-ever monthly sales.

Domestic passenger vehicle wholesales in October are estimated in the range of 525,000-530,000 units, against 460,000 units in October 2025. This should represent growth of around 13–15% year-on-year despite a high base in the year-ago period. "My take is, the industry should be between 5.25–5.3 lakh units," said Partho Banerjee, senior executive officer at Maruti Suzuki. Market leader Maruti Suzuki reported domestic passenger vehicle dispatches of 212,000 units in October, which represents growth of 20% y-o-y. Tata Motors recorded 21% growth to 73,894 units, while M&M posted a 2% rise to record 73,338 units. **PTI**

Power use rises 21.88% in October

India's power consumption grew 21.88% year-on-year to 159.76 billion units (BU) in October, largely fuelled by increased commercial and industrial demand amid ongoing festival season and also continuous use of cooling appliances across the country.

The country's total power consumption was 131.07 BU in October 2025.

According to experts, the rise in commercial and industrial demand of electricity amid ongoing festival season as well as continuous use of cooling appliances October in many parts of the country pushed power consumptions in the month. The peak power demand also jumped to 260.73GW last month from 210.82GW in October 2025. India's peak power demand had hit the record high of 270.82GW in May 2026. The Ministry of Power has projected 270GW of peak power demand during the summer season in 2026. **PTI**

DivyaSree, HDFC Cap set up platform

DivyaSree Developers is stepping up its residential ambitions with a ₹1,500 crore platform alongside HDFC Capital Advisors Ltd, seeking to build a ₹6,750 crore development pipeline over the next three to four years as the commercial property developer looks to diversify its business.

The platform will provide growth capital for acquiring and developing residential projects across multiple cities. The partnership is expected to strengthen DivyaSree's residential pipeline and help it tap opportunities in key property markets in the country. "DivyaSree's residential business is at an inflection point. This platform gives us the growth capital and momentum to move faster on that plan. Going forward, while commercial will remain the largest business in the foreseeable future, residential is likely to be the fastest growing for the company," Avinash Suresh, chief executive—residential real estate, DivyaSree Developers, said in an interview. **MADHURIMA NANDY**

Creators and stand-up comics are driving live-events boom

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Music remains a major driver of India's live entertainment economy, but creator-led formats are one of the fastest-growing parts of the mix. According to the Ficci-EY 2026 report, organised live events grew 44% in 2025, with ticketed events among the key drivers. However, industry experts have flagged that the concert market overheated late in the year. That makes the diversification toward other formats even more relevant.

Creators arrive with a built-in digital audience, which translates naturally into tours and new live formats. Comedy has built the most mature live ecosystem, from open mics and clubs to arena-scale tours, and is travelling well beyond the metros into tier II and III cities. Zakir Khan's *Papa Yaar* tour covered numerous cities and shows, while comedians like Akash Gupta and Gaurav Kapoor regularly do international shows. Creators are also experimenting with live conversations, podcasts, interactive shows and IP-led experiences, experts point out.

The organized live events segment is expected to grow from ₹14,500 crore in 2025 to ₹19,600 crore by 2028, the Ficci-EY report showed.

Music remained a key driver of India's live entertainment economy. ISTOCKPHOTO

"Comedy is now firmly among the top categories in India's live entertainment business and the shape of that business has changed dramatically," said Anil Makhija, chief operating officer, live entertainment and venues, BookMyShow. Some of the most popular names in the business are now experimenting with stadium formats, a scale that would have been unthinkable for a comedy show even a few years ago. As a genre, comedy has grown by 15% year-on-year for the past two years and that momentum shows no signs of slowing, Makhija added.

Live events overall are growing, and that growth is increasingly coming from beyond the metros, according to Pranav Panpalia, co-founder, Opraah, a creator agency.

"The biggest driver is the relationship creators have already built online. When someone has spent years building a community on YouTube or Instagram, a live show gives that community a chance to come together in a far more personal, participative way," said Sheetal Birla, general manager India, Live Your City.

Bhakti Vaza, senior manager, client servicing at BC Web Wise, a digital marketing agency, said for years, social media was where creators built reach. Today, live events are where they build relationships. "In metros, we're seeing audiences gravitate towards premium experiences like live podcasts, comedy specials and creator festivals. But the more exciting growth is happening in tier II cities. Places like Jaipur, Surat and Guwahati are proving that demand isn't limited to Mumbai or Bengaluru. In many of these markets, a creator's visit becomes a cultural event because audiences have been consuming their content for years but rarely get to experience it in person," Vaza said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Japanese deal rush keeps law firms busy as India bets grow

FROM PAGE 1

data shows.

With Japanese companies reassessing their exposure to China amid rising competitive and profitability pressures, India is emerging as an attractive destination for long-term expansion. Against projected global growth of approximately 3.1%, emerging-market growth of around 3.7% and relatively modest growth across major advanced economies, India's growth trajectory stands out, Pandey said.

India's expanding network of free trade agreements also offers Japanese businesses opportunities to collaborate with Indian companies, establish manufacturing operations and use the country as an export hub.

"We are witnessing growing interest from Japanese corporations, financial institutions, private capital investors and, increasingly, small and medium enterprises. I expect this diversification to sustain strong momentum in cross-border M&A, joint ventures and investment activity over the coming decade," Pandey added.

Japanese venture capital (VC) firms and institutional investors are also increasingly shifting their focus from Southeast Asia to India, drawn by stronger IPO momentum, rising exit opportunities and a more vibrant technology start-up ecosystem, Mint reported earlier.

Japanese firms are reassessing their exposure to China. ISTOCKPHOTO

BeyondNext Ventures, Enrision India Capital, Incubate Fund Asia and Genesia Ventures are among the Japanese VC firms exploring India more aggressively as investments in their home market and Southeast Asia have failed to deliver significant exits.

The growing activity has translated into more business for law firms advising Japanese clients. Firms are responding by forging partnerships with Japanese law firms and hiring lawyers to handle the potential increase in work.

In September, Argus Partners hired an entire team led by Saurav Kumar from CMS IndusLaw. Kumar joined as senior partner in the firm's corporate and M&A practice and head of its Japan and South Korea desk.

"The nature of engagements in this corridor has broadened considerably, with significant deal activity emerging in green investments, critical manufacturing and new-age technology sectors. As transactions in these specialized domains were historically uncommon in the Indian market, they introduce intricate regulatory, legal and operational complexities that demand an exceptionally high calibre of legal expertise," said Kumar.

On the private capital side, the pace of activity has also picked up. Around half a dozen deals and investment announcements have emerged over the past 12-18 months, including the transactions and partnerships involving MUFG, SMBC, Mizuho and DBJ.

"These are not small stakes or small deals. They are large, complex acquisitions involving significant investments by Japanese financial institutions. This reflects growing confidence in their understanding of India's legal and regulatory environment, and a deep conviction in the country's growth story," said Rishabh Shroff, partner, co-head of private client and head of international business development at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas.

Such transactions require expertise in complex financial-sector M&A, backed by capabilities across tax, intellectual property and regulatory practice areas, he said.

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OF BRIDGES UNDER TROUBLED WATERS

Infrastructure projects in India are frequently laid low by shoddy quality. Where does the problem lie?

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Several vehicles fell into the Mahisagar river following the collapse of a portion of a bridge over the river in Mujpur, near Vadodara in Gujarat, on 9 July last year; (Bottom) Workers repair rain-damaged stretches of the Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway in Uttar Pradesh. HT

mint KEY NUMBERS

72
Number of projects that have collapsed or shown major defects on National Highways from 2020-2025, per official data

~₹3.4 TRILLION
Cumulative cost overrun of infrastructure projects worth more than ₹150 crore, according to MoSPI

750+
Number of projects facing delays ranging from 12 months to over eight years, per MoSPI, due to land acquisition, slow clearances

The cracks began to appear within weeks. In mid-July, the 63-kilometre, six-lane Kanpur-Lucknow expressway, built at a cost of ₹4,200 crore, had opened with much fanfare. Inaugurated by a glittering cast of political leaders, including Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath and road transport and highways minister Nitin Gadkari, it was expected to cut travel time between the two cities from 2-3 hours to 30-40 minutes.

By early August though, dozens of potholes pockmarked the expressway, forcing The National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) to partially close it for repairs. For commuters, the promise of a seamless drive across vast fields quickly faded as the highway turned into a makeshift repair site. Industrial fans lined the route to dry the wet, crumbling road, and excavators and roadrollers worked to patch damaged portions, pushing traffic onto diversions and stopping heavy vehicles from using the highway altogether.

Similarly, in July, the ₹16-crore approach road near Dehradun's Nanda Ki Chowki bridge caved in just 16 days after inauguration. A month earlier, a ₹26-crore railway road overbridge in Buxar suffered partial structural failure and came apart days after opening.

Last July, the Gambhira Bridge in Vadodara district collapsed, sending vehicles into the Mahi river, killing 22 people and severing a vital transport link. The tragedy came less than three years after a 19th century suspension bridge in Morbi, also in Gujarat, collapsed barely five days after it was opened during the Diwali season. The footbridge, touted by the state's tourism department as an "artistic and technological marvel", was opened after six months of renovation by a private company. About 140 people were killed, 55 of them children, and many more injured when it came apart on 30 October 2022.

Bridges, tunnels, highways and key public infrastructure have long stood as symbols of the country's culture, history, and engineering prowess, becoming crucial lifelines for connectivity and commerce. In recent years, many such projects have been inaugurated, including the Chenab Rail Bridge in Jammu and Kashmir, the world's highest railway arch bridge; the Sela Tunnel in Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh, located at an altitude of over 13,000 feet; Mumbai's Atal Setu, India's longest sea bridge; and the New Pamban Bridge in Tamil Nadu, the country's first vertical-lift railway sea bridge. And yet, many of India's infrastructure projects frequently suffer failures during or after construction, sometimes taking a heavy toll in lives.

The list of infrastructural failures is long. According to government figures, a total of 72 projects have either collapsed or shown major deficiencies on national highway stretches from 2020 to 2025. Media reports suggest the figure is far higher—over 170 bridge and flyover failures between 2021 and 2025.

So, why do these disasters occur, and why do they occur so frequently?

NATION BUILDING NO LONGER

According to urban researcher Aravind Unni, construction quality, as well as the nature and scale of disasters, have changed, with a direct impact on urban modern infrastructure. "In the past, infrastructure was built to last—designed to withstand almost anything. The projects we built, like dams, were built with a 100-year perspective. They were more than just mega-projects; they were about nation-building," he says.

The emphasis on delivering projects in compressed timelines can often come at the cost of quality.

In the case of the Kanpur-Lucknow expressway, for instance, a team of experts from Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur engaged by the NHAI reportedly found that the highly plastic soil, which is fine-grained silt used as the foundation underneath the thick upper layers, was the likely cause of the cracks. It was found to be weak, lost structural strength when wet, and shifted under heavy loads. Plastic soil is usually stabilized with chemicals to reduce its moisture sensitivity.

Added to this was an inadequate drainage system, and unpaved shoulders of the expressway meant for further expansion, which allowed water to accumulate and become trapped beneath the pavement, further destabilizing the base. Currently, repairs are being carried out on about 80 patches on the expressway.

According to the findings of the state government's probe into the incident, the Gambhira bridge collapse was caused by structural failure—systemic corrosion over time and a crushing of the pedestal and articulation joints that support the deck of the bridge on which vehicles ply. These critical support points connecting separate sections disintegrated under vehicular pressure, decay, and structural fatigue.

A special investigation team looking into the Morbi collapse blamed it on severe structural corrosion, shoddy repair work, and extreme overcrowding. Nearly half of the wires of one of the two main cables of the suspension bridge were corroded, it found. Old suspenders were welded with new ones, and the walking structure was made up of rigid aluminium panels instead of flexible wooden planks.

SYSTEMIC ISSUE

According to construction, engineering and infrastructure consultant Devanshu Pandit, while India has undertaken a massive amount of infrastructural projects, it does not yet have the capacity to match the demand.

> Contractors don't always have the capacity to deliver. Smaller ones allegedly undercut prices and take a loss just to add a government project to their credentials

"We are missing sufficient equipment and manpower. Contractors are moving up the ladder despite not always having the necessary experience or manpower. We need stricter qualifications based on the amount of work a contractor can handle, their technical capacity and the value of projects they have the ability to execute," says Pandit. "We need to have better checks and balances and supervision by third-party consultants who perform their role effectively. This model can work well. But when the supervision goes to an urban local body, it can become an issue if they are simply used as a rubber stamp."

An official from the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH), who did not want to be named, admitted that the rapid pace of project execution does impact the quality of work. One key reason, he told *Mint*, is that low bidders, typically smaller contractors, are aggressively undercutting prices and are willing to take a loss just to build their portfolios and add a major government project to their credentials.

To be sure, India needs infrastructure, and is finally giving it the attention and money that is needed. The flow of funds into central capital expenditure, of which a large sum is spent building roads, highways and other public connectivity infrastructure, has significantly increased to ₹12.2 trillion ($133 billion) in the current financial year. It is driven by the ₹11.11 trillion National Infrastructure Pipeline, with top allocations for MoRTH (₹2.8 trillion) and Indian Railways (₹2.52 trillion).

Yet, there have been major cost overruns, according to recent monthly flash reports on central sector infrastructure projects published by the ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI). Infrastructure projects worth more than ₹150 crore each recorded a cumulative cost overrun of approximately ₹3.4 trillion ($40 billion) while 750+ projects face delays, ranging from 12 months to over eight years, in part due to land acquisition and slow environmental clearances.

REMEDIAL MEASURES

Mint approached the NHAI and MoRTH seeking details on how they were addressing failures and poor-quality infrastructure across the country.

In the case of the Kanpur-Lucknow expressway, heads began to roll soon after the cracks appeared: NHAI disqualified the contracted construction firm, M/s PNC Infratech Ltd, from future agency bids. It also issued a show-cause notice proposing a 2% performance security penalty and directed the company to rectify the damaged stretch at its own cost, approximately ₹3 crore.

An NHAI representative told *Mint* that "adequate measures have been taken against non-compliant firms" contracted to build its projects. "There is a 15-year defect liability period, and in the case of the contractor responsible for the Kanpur-Lucknow project, we have debarred the firm for three years. The government is not bearing the repair costs—the firm will cover everything, including lost toll revenue," the representative added.

After the Gambhira Bridge collapse, the Gujarat government suspended four engineers from the roads and buildings department for negligence and launched a statewide safety audit of over 1,800 bridges. It resulted in the immediate closure or heavy-vehicle restriction on many of them due to more than 130 structural risks.

The central government, meanwhile, primarily through MoRTH, has enforced nationwide mandatory pre- and post-monsoon bridge inspections under updated safety standard operating procedures, including specialized underwater and scour-depth assessments for major river crossings, and fast-tracked real-time safety data integration into the Indian Bridge Management System (IBMS).

Additionally, independent empanelled experts have been mandated to conduct immediate root-cause reviews, while third-party structural safety clearances have been made mandatory before traffic on any aging or compromised bridges is restored.

Last month, MoRTH announced bridge monitoring would be separated from routine highway contracts and assigned to specialized agencies to detect early structural deterioration and prevent collapses. While these agencies manage hardware, sensors, and real-time data transmission, IIT Madras and the centre for development of advanced computing will develop the analytical software.

"We are fixing the alignment of all stakeholders involved in infrastructure projects. For example, we are streamlining permissions across departments, including environment, which were causing delays in projects and leading to increased costs. Second, we are fixing concerns in the planning stage," C. N. Singh, a MoRTH joint secretary, told *Mint*. "For example, the detailed planning report (DPR) wasn't being done professionally. We found the lowest bid process being followed was leading to shoddy, low-quality work. So, a root cause analysis was done and it led to a change. Now, selection is done on a fixed, fair rate and the firm's previous ratings."

Another concern across government departments has been the human toll of infrastructural flaws. "People dying on the roads is a bane. We are creating more accountability—if such accidents happen, the company that has done the DPR will be blacklisted as well. Additionally, we studied the last 10 years of PPP agreements and found the root causes that led to arbitration and changed them because it was having a long-term impact on the use of public funds," he added.

Mint reached out to several prominent construction firms contracted to build public infrastructure for comments on key issues, but did not receive a response.

THE WAY FORWARD

Rather than acting after issues crop up, experts believe that quality should receive priority from the design stage itself and monitored throughout the lifespan of a structure. One of the ways to achieve infrastructure that is built to last at least 75 years is by transitioning from predominantly reactive maintenance towards predictive maintenance, says Suresh Bhalla, professor (higher administrative grade) at the department of civil and environmental engineering, IIT Delhi. Integrating real-time, sensor-driven monitoring, which is still at a nascent stage in India, can serve as a continuous information backbone to prevent accidents and failures, he added.

"It is imperative that critical infrastructure be instrumented with a basic structural health monitoring (SHM) system from the construction stage itself, with the provision to progressively scale up its capabilities as the structure ages and its monitoring requirements evolve... Systematic monitoring of response data can enable early identification of anomalies, deterioration and potentially unsafe trends, allowing timely investigation and corrective intervention," Bhalla told *Mint*.

To this end, the smart structures and dynamics laboratory at IIT Delhi has developed more than a dozen sensor systems to apply to real-life infrastructure in India. It has also incubated a startup, Sanrachna Prahari Private Limited, to commercialise and deploy these technologies.

The goal should be to make SHM an integral component of the infrastructure lifecycle strategy, "beginning with construction, evolving through operation and maintenance, and ultimately contributing to safer, more resilient and economically sustainable infrastructure," added Bhalla.

Additionally, there needs to be a shift in design thinking to make it more aligned with what is environmentally more sustainable, says urban researcher Unni. "Bigger does not necessarily mean more resilient. We need porous infrastructure that lets water through naturally (such as on riverbanks), along with a shift in broader design. The devastating impact of the recent floods in Nepal has made it more urgent to ensure future guidelines are more alert to the geographical vulnerabilities of local terrain."

As scrutiny from government bodies, engineering experts, and sustainability advocates grows, the hope is that a mindshift change and greater accountability will ensure that as India builds bigger, it also builds better.

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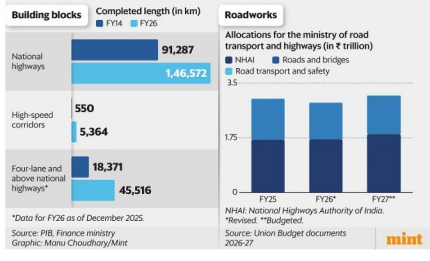
Road roll

India needs infrastructure, and is finally giving it the attention and money that is needed



*Data for FY26 as of December 2025.
NHAI: National Highways Authority of India. *Revised. **Budgeted.
Source: PIB, Finance ministry
Source: Union Budget documents 2026-27
Graphic: Manu Choudhary/Mint

How to declutter your stock and MF portfolios this festive season

Keep 8-10 schemes, revisit your asset allocation and trim overlapping funds, excessive sectoral or thematic bets

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MUMBAI

Alongside celebrations, India's festival season is also a time for clearing out cupboards, closets and homes. It may be a good time to turn your attention to something less visible but equally in need of a clean-up: your investment portfolio

Over time, investments can accumulate across mutual funds and direct stocks, often with overlapping holdings or little contribution to overall returns. Keeping track of them, and assessing how each fits into the larger portfolio, can become an increasingly complicated exercise.

A leaner portfolio makes it easier to monitor investments, assess performance and stay aligned with financial goals. Here is how to go about decluttering, starting with mutual funds and then moving to stocks.

Decluttering your MF portfolio

Make a list of all your investments. Your consolidated account statement (CAS) provides a view in a single document. You can download it from registrars CAMS and KFin Technologies, or through MF Central.

Next, revisit your asset allocation—split between equity, debt and gold. "Check if an MF investment has significantly distorted from the original asset allocation and if any trimming is needed there to re-balance the portfolio," said Vishal Dhawan, founder of Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors. "Eight-ten schemes should be adequate for most, depending on goals and timelines," said Nisreen Mamaji, founder, MoneyWorks Financial Services.

A core-and-satellite structure can keep the portfolio manageable. The core, comprising diversified equity or index funds, debt fund and gold, must be aligned with long- to mid-term goals. "You can keep a well-diversified core portfolio with funds complementing each other well. Change only when a fund lags its category and benchmark for several quarters," said Deepak Chhabria, CEO and director at Axiom Financial Services.

The satellite portion is where clutter can build up. Sectoral and thematic funds, new fund offers (NFOs) and last year's top performers can all find their way into a portfolio. Keep this allocation small and be selective.

Same category schemes may hold same stocks, especially for large-caps. Portfolios with too many equity funds "starts to resemble broader markets," blunting its ability to outperform, said Ankur Punj, managing director and business head at Equirus Wealth.

A Nifty 50 index fund can do that job at a lower cost.

Most Indian equity funds follow a growth-oriented investment style. A value or contra fund can offer some balance. Fund-house concentration is another factor to consider. "If you have too many mutual funds from the same fund house, consider trimming your exposure there, to mitigate any impact on your portfolio if a fund manager happens to quit or the fund house runs into a period of underperformance due to its investment philosophy," Chhabria added.

"Equity funds that make up less than 5% of a portfolio, and that you no longer add to, can go. Even a strong run in it will barely move your overall returns," Amol Joshi, founder of Plan Rupee Investment Services, said.

Declutter your stock portfolio

The same principle applies to direct equity holdings. Too many stocks can make it difficult to identify underperformers and assess what each holding contributes.

"The more holdings you have, the harder it is to spot the laggards, and beyond a point the portfolio simply tracks the market," Punj said.

Start by getting a consolidated view of your holdings. These are available through your broker's app or website. If you have multiple demat accounts, you can download a consolidated account statement from the depositories—National Securities Depository Ltd or Central Depository Services (India) Ltd.

Looking at direct holdings alongside mutual fund investments can also reveal overlaps that may otherwise go unnoticed. For instance, holding HDFC Bank and ICICI Bank shares as a large part of your direct stock portfolio, while also owning three large-cap funds, could leave you with substantial exposure to the banking sector. Banks carry significant weight in frontline benchmark indices, and large-cap funds typically have considerable exposure to the segment.

Just like with mutual funds, it is also important to keep track of your stock investments.

"Check for stocks with less than 1% weights and sell them if they are not adding any value to the overall portfolio. Review the thesis you had in mind for each stock and see if it still holds good. If you don't recollect the thesis or bought it on just a tip, then sell it regardless of its performance. Use the freed-up cash to invest in a sounder stock or mutual fund. Weakening of a company's fundamentals could be another reason to sell a stock," said Aarati Krishnan, head of advisory at PrimeInvestor Financial Research.

Keep taxes in mind

A portfolio clean-up should also account for the tax implications of selling investments. Capital gains taxes may apply, so the order and timing of sales matter.

Prioritize selling loss-making investments first. If you end up booking some capital losses, it can be used later to offset capital gains and save on taxes. Remember, you can adjust short-term capital loss against both short term and long-term capital gains in any financial year. Long-term capital loss can be set off only against long-term gains.

If you are looking to sell an underperforming mutual fund or stock with little profits, use the ₹1.25 lakh exemption limit. When it comes to equities, long-term capital gains up to ₹1.25 lakh are tax-exempt each financial year. Holding period of more than 12 months is required for an equity investment to get long-term capital gains treatment.

"You can plan some tranche of selling before 31 March and some afterwards as new financial year begins from 1 April. This way you can use the tax-exemption limit twice in the same calendar year," said Harshal Bhuta, co-founder and country co-head, international tax & FEMA, Ascentium India.

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Can MF sale proceeds help you save tax on a house purchase?

Parizad Sirwalla

I moved to Luxembourg in February and sold mutual funds last month. Can I claim Section 54F relief by buying a house in Delhi?
—Name withheld on request

Section 86 of the Income-tax Act, 2025 (erstwhile Section 54F) allows individuals and Hindu Undivided Families (HUFs) to claim exemption on long-term capital gains from selling assets other than residential units, by investing sale proceeds in a house in India. Benefit is available to both residents and non-residents. Since you sold MF units, you may qualify if you meet the following conditions:

- Investment timeline: Buy a house within one year before or two years after the sale, or construct one in three years.
- Extent of exemption: Investing the entire sale consideration qualifies the entire LTCG for exemption. Partial investment attracts proportionate exemption.
- Capital Gains Account Scheme: Deposit unutilized proceeds in the scheme by the income-tax return filing deadline to retain the exemption.
- ₹10-crore cap: The cost of new house and net sale consideration considered for exemption are capped at ₹10 crore.
- Three-year lock-in: Do not sell the new house within three years of purchase or construction; otherwise, the exemption may be withdrawn.
- Existing property ownership: You must not own more than one other residential house on the date of sale.
- Additional house restriction: Buying another house within one year of the sale or constructing one within three years may trigger tax on the exemption claimed.

So, you may claim Section 86 relief on eligible gains from the sale of your MFs by investing the proceeds in a house in Delhi. Any tax implications in Luxembourg should be examined separately.

Parizad Sirwalla is partner and head, global mobility services, tax, KPMG in India.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.

	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	20%	12.5%*
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Reits/InVITs	>12 months	20%	12.5%
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs^, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	12.5%
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments.
MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; Reits: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InVITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. ^gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FoF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: *Mint* Research

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

mint

EPFO services via WhatsApp begins

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Union labour and employment minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Sunday rolled out Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) services through WhatsApp.

Under the EPFO Services through WhatsApp, the EPF subscribers will be able to access their PF balance, latest five transactions and passbook information through EPFO's verified WhatsApp service, besides receiving personalised guidance and assistance in completing PMVBRY-related requirements, a labour ministry statement said.

This will make routine services accessible via a mobile platform and reduce the need to visit EPFO offices. On the occasion of EPFO's 74th Foundation Day Celebration, the minister also launched automatic Settlement of Eligible Inoperative EPF Accounts. Subscribers having Aadhaar-verified inoperative EPF accounts with balances up to ₹1,000 will not be required to file individual claims.

The EPFO will initiate settlement automatically after prescribed identity and bank-account verification, facilitating transfer of eligible dues to rightful beneficiaries.

Approximately 100,000 accounts involving ₹5 crore are expected to benefit.

Seven publications were released on the occasion, reflecting EPFO's commitment to knowledge creation, institutional learning, legal awareness and compassionate governance.

Speaking on the occasion, Mandaviya highlighted that over its 74-year journey, EPFO has emerged as a trusted institution for the workforce of the country. He noted that the trust reposed in the Organisation is reflected in the ₹32 lakh crore corpus accumulated through contributions from more than 80 million members, made possible by the dedication, hard work and commitment of the EPFO workforce. The Union minister urged officials to focus on worker-centric innovations across domains in the run-up to EPFO's 75th year, adapting, building resilience, and evolving processes in tandem with changing times.

WHEN NOTHING WORKS, WHAT DO GREAT INVESTORS DO?
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We welcome your views and comments at **mintmoney@livemint.com**

OVERSEAS MF BETS: CAP THE INVESTOR, NOT THE INDUSTRY

A few days ago, at an event in Delhi, I asked RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra about a strange situation for Indians who want to invest abroad, who have two main routes.

The first route is via Indian mutual funds investing abroad. It works like domestic mutual funds: you invest in rupees, can start small and run SIPs, and the funds are regulated by Sebi. But this route has been largely blocked since 2022. Mutual funds together face a $7 billion ceiling on overseas investments, plus a separate $1 billion limit for foreign exchange-traded funds (ETFs). The RBI set these limits in April 2008 and has not raised them since, despite the industry's explosive growth. In 2008, mutual funds managed about ₹3 trillion; today, they manage over ₹80 trillion.

The second route is via GIFT City. Under Liberalized Remittance Scheme (LRS), Indians can remit up to $250,000 a fiscal year abroad, including into dollar-denominated funds launched by some asset management companies (AMCs) in GIFT City. This route has its own regulator and is not bound by the $7 billion ceiling. I wrote approvingly about it a few months ago and still believe large investors should understand it. But it is not suited to someone looking to start a ₹5,000 SIP. The minimum investment is usually $5,000, some feeder funds cost nearly 3% all-in, and remittances above ₹10 lakh a year attract 20% tax collected at source (TCS), tying up money even if eventually refunded.

The business has gone there anyway. Fund houses have lined up to launch GIFT City funds for resident Indians: five opened by July, and more have since. The pooled cap did not stop money from leaving the country. It only decided who could take it out.

Tighter leash on overseas investments?

Malhotra said RBI was monitoring investments through the GIFT City route. Then, disarmingly, he turned the question around and asked me what I thought should be done.

PAN-linked investment data can help track individual exposure across fund houses

Meanwhile, the stakes have gone up. A business channel carried a 'source-based' report that RBI has suggested to the Centre that investment remittances under LRS that need no approval today, should each need RBI approval. If something like this happened, and the governor said the RBI was watching GIFT City flows, practically every route for investing abroad would be shut.

Here is my considered answer. The basic issue is that the well-regulated, cheaper, easier way to invest in the world is shut, while the costly, complex way that only the rich can use remains open.

Cap the investor, not the industry

The main route for investing abroad must work like domestic mutual fund. If the worry is that money leaving the country must be watched, this is the cleaner solution, because every rupee goes through a Sebi-regulated fund house. And democratizing investing abroad means opening the mutual fund route, not rationing it to those with wealth to spare for an offshore account.

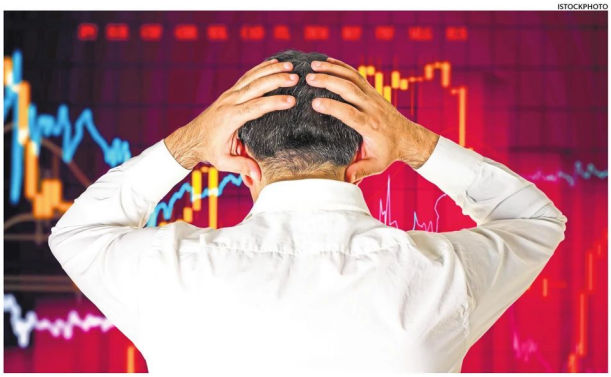
Second, and most importantly, the limit should be per person and annual, not a single pooled limit for the entire country. A modest per-person annual cap, say $10,000, would let the RBI defend reserves without shutting out small investors because big investors got to the pooled limit first. $10,000 a year is enough for a monthly SIP of over ₹70,000, far more than most small investors need. It would also control what leaves the country each year, which is what matters for the rupee. The pooled limit is a blunt instrument. Once it is full, it shuts the door on everyone.

A per-person limit may not have been practical in 2008, because tracking one investor's foreign investing across fund houses would have been hard, if not impossible. Now, with PAN and Aadhaar linked to every investment account, that problem has gone. The industry's registrars can already see each investor's holdings across fund houses by PAN.

Some global diversification is an important part of a portfolio. So, that's my answer to the RBI: cap the investor, not the industry. A modest annual limit per person would serve the regulatory purpose while also giving investors who need it most an easy route.

Dhirendra Kumar is founder and CEO of Value Research.

OUR VIEW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India's market slump: No palliatives please

Changes in the capital gains tax alone won't bring back foreign investors. Policymakers need to push through reforms to drive the growth of high-value globally competitive firms

Indian equities rank among the worst performing emerging market assets today, despite the rebound in October. The benchmark Nifty 50 index has fallen 12% this year (17% in dollar terms), Bloomberg data shows. Among major emerging markets, only Indonesian equities have fared worse, with the benchmark IDX Composite index falling 4.2% this year (46% in dollar terms), following a warning from Morgan Stanley Capital International (MSCI) that Indonesia might lose its emerging market status.

The slump in Indian markets is partly because of large-scale selling by foreign portfolio investors (FPIs), who have pulled out about ₹3 trillion from Indian equity markets so far this year, a decadal high. The outflows have weakened the rupee, and in turn lowered the dollar returns foreign investors earn from Indian equities.

There are several contending explanations for the slump. One thesis points to the lack of artificial intelligence (AI) firms in the country. Since investors have poured gazillions of dollars into AI firms and AI-linked sectors, India has lost out. As the AI trade weakens, India would stand to gain, according to this thesis.

A second thesis emphasizes geopolitical tensions that have pushed up commodity prices. As a large commodity importer, India has been hit harder than the rest. Related to this, rising inflation and bond yields in the US have narrowed the spread between US and emerging market assets, weakening fund flows to emerging markets. As geopolitical tensions subside and the global commodity cycle cools, India would be back in favour, the proponents of this thesis argue.

A third thesis emphasizes the lack of innovation among large Indian firms. Without the promise of sustained earnings growth, Indian stocks would remain unattractive to foreign investors, Bernstein Research analysts Venugopal Garre and Nikhil Arela wrote in a note to clients a few weeks ago. If the AI trade weakens, or oil prices decline, foreign capital might return temporarily. But sustained flows would depend on "whether India can create new engines of competitiveness, innovation and global relevance," they wrote. The new firms emerging in areas such as space, defence, semiconductors and deep-tech are currently too small to attract global capital at scale, the duo argued.

None of these explanations suggest that changes in capital gains taxes can bring back foreign funds. To be sure, there are distortions in our capital tax structure, and this should be addressed, as this newspaper has argued earlier (see 'LTCG and STT: Optimize taxes that investors pay,' 19 October). Rationalizing capital gains taxes would help foreign and domestic investors choose more appropriate assets for themselves. But they are not a quick-fix to stem capital outflows.

The repricing of stocks in the current slump could itself rekindle interest in Indian markets. It is worth noting that foreign investors have invested heavily in initial public offerings in the recent past even as they have avoided overpriced stocks in the secondary market.

Policymakers should focus on difficult reforms that could catalyse the growth of high-value globally competitive firms in the country. These firms should be free to dedicate their resources to develop innovative products rather than expend them in managing the bureaucracy.

MY VIEW | THE INTERSECTION

Ibn Khaldun's ideas tell us much about our tech services industry

The industry must cannibalize its own businesses with new ones so as not to get upstaged by others

NITIN PAI
is co-founder and director of The Takshashila Institution, an independent centre for research and education in public policy

Watching India's information technology (IT) services companies discuss the extent of what they call "AI revenue deflation" in recent weeks, I was reminded of Ibn Khaldun, the 14th century North African scholar. He wrote about civilizations and empires, not technology companies, but the outline of his observations are useful in understanding where our tech giants are and, more importantly, what they might have to do to continue to thrive.

Khaldun argued that societies rise and fall in cycles. Founders triumph over adversity and create a political institution. They are followed by builders who carry forward the growth. Next come the inheritors who rest on their laurels, and are finally succeeded by those who preside over loss and disintegration. Like the Chinese proverb that gave wealth three generations, Khaldun framed the life of a state in four phases. The founding generations succeed in the desert because they are held together by a force of solidarity that he calls *Asabiyya*, which weakens amid the luxuries of the city and the injustices in an enlarged empire. The decline happens when expenditure exceeds income and mercenaries fill the ranks. The empire is then overthrown by a new group with stronger *asabiyya*.

Now there are instances of dynasties and empires around the world lasting much longer than four generations, so Khaldun's cycle is not destiny. It does, however, other things for us. It tells us that the leaders and the circumstances they face are different at different times, and things that worked for the previous senior management team might not work for the current one. We are alerted to how *asabiyya*—solidarity, coherence and a sense of common purpose—might be weakening amid growth, luxury, careerism and internal competition. Companies more than empires find their options shrinking when margins get tighter, increasing the chances of mistakes and bad decisions. Finally, someone faster, nimbler and younger eats your lunch.

It is not an exaggeration to claim that the first generation of the Indian IT services industry were heroic: starting up in the licence-permit raj and then convincing a sceptical world of India's technological and professional capabilities is nothing but that. Not just founders but industry figures like the late Dewang Mehta were champions and cheerleaders who persuaded global investors and enterprises to put their money in India in the 1990s. That was a time when it was not clear whether India would persist with economic reforms, manage the proxy war in Jammu and Kashmir and navigate out of economic sanctions following the nuclear rests. Sure, Y2K, business process outsourcing and the rest rescued us, but only because industry leaders sold the India story to the world. Contrary what some people might now believe, the global IT business didn't fall on the laps of software engineers chilling out in Bengaluru's parks.

I do not know which Khaldun phase our IT services companies are in today but I do not see any senior industry figure make bold declarations of how Indian industry is best placed to capture the global market for artificial intelligence (AI) adoption. It is understandable that CEOs must account for slower revenue growth amid rising AI-related work, but such a conservative managerial approach completely ignores the size of the global opportunity and India's readiness to capture it. This Indian fastidiousness is in sharp contrast to American extravagance: Anthropic has declared that, at over $30 trillion, its total addressable market is as large as the US economy.

The notion that the world's enterprises will directly engage Anthropic or any other AI company to handle their IT work is absurd. They will continue to need services companies—and unless their current Indian vendors satisfy the new productivity and cost requirements, the business will flow to new ones that can. As Tech Mahindra's Mohit Joshi says, "...this AI deflation is way overdone. The reality is that clients are expecting productivity from AI, but this is maybe slightly different in terms of magnitude. But this is no different from the productivity that clients were earlier expecting from consolidation, that they were expecting from agile, that they were expecting it from sort of simplification, and then from automation, and now from AI."

Some Indian IT majors might indeed be in the "luxury of the city" phase, although I doubt the best of them are. It is more likely that they are caught in the legacy trap: existing multi-year contracts that can be delivered with adjustments to existing delivery models. Looking at what some CEOs are saying, this is perhaps the mechanism underlying AI revenue deflation. It is easy to advocate change, but cutting bonuses, freezing hiring or laying off tens of thousands of people is something that few Indian business leaders have ever had to do.

In Khaldun's calculus, you have to become your own barbarian in order not to be upstaged by a new one. This not only means setting up units that will cannibalize your legacy business, but also through markets around the world. That is the kind of noise that foreign investors will hear loud and clear.

10 YEARS AGO

mint

Amit Mitra asks centre to come clean on GST

Price, bundling and costs: Intel's recipe to combat Jio

It's free, mutual funds vet to UC to split holdings

JUST A THOUGHT

"Nations and empires flourish and decay, by turns command, and in their turns obey.

OVID

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

How cheap labour from India has made London kinder

MANU JOSEPH

is a journalist, novelist and screenwriter. His latest book is 'Why the Poor Don't Kill Us.'

Part of our dying heritage is the dance of two Indian strangers as they approach each other on the street of an advanced economy. They avert their gaze, lower their heads, veer a little, as though to escape being bound by the same origin story. It is a ritual of sophistication, and it had its heydays when the chances were high that two Indians on such a street were from the upper class. Now something has changed, at least in London. There are so many Indians in any given hour that they ignore each other, or they just gape because most of them are poor or lower-middle-class migrants. They are here to do work that English people had said they would do themselves after driving away Europeans in the name of Brexit.

The growth of the transient low-wage worker in London, led by Indians, has been extraordinary. Even two years ago, they were not this common. As a result, they have altered the public face of most of London. They have made it far less intimidating, and more amiable, informal and compassionate. This happens to a city when its visible workers don't have the swag of equality.

Not long ago, the typical cafe in London was run by locals, or East European migrants whose tolerance for alien mannerisms and the misdemeanours of customers was low. In the superstore, when the attendant was speaking to a customer, you did not interject. The waiter carrying a tray filled with plates could not be stopped to be asked a question. When the barista's back was towards you, making coffee, they could not hear you. Everywhere, workers did only one thing at a time. Once, a street-side vendor was making a pancake, and an Indian made an order, as Indians do. The vendor raised his arms: "I only have two hands."

London was particularly intimidating for Indians and other Asians who are accustomed to servility from people who do menial jobs. Just because a board said, "Please wait to be seated," must they be rebuked for grabbing a table?

All that has gone, in most of London. Now it is poor migrants from poor countries who work at these places. When someone is passing an instruction to the kitchen, you can ask them a question about choices of milk, and they will not vibrate in disorientation. A worker in a superstore who is rushing somewhere can be interrupted with a question.

Indians have also transformed the public character of London in an odd way. Now the support staff speaks English. Twenty years ago, you could not be assured of getting by in Central London using English if you needed assistance, say, in the tube stations. Physically, London is too beautiful, too clean, too orderly, and its government too humane, to be an Indian city. But inside many buildings it feels like India.

India's training of its poor to never feel empowered enough, to always know "your place," and to never take seriously democracy's biggest humbug, that all are equal, makes them good workers in jobs that the locals in the UK don't want to do.

India's training of its poor to always know 'their place' makes them good workers in London

Migrants have also changed British homes. Britain's upper middle class is beginning to resemble ours. They are pampered by cheap help. Chauffeurs are not common for them, but nannies are not rare anymore.

The money is good for the migrants. The UK is the new Gulf for many Indians, including Malayalee nurses who are in demand. But most migrants I spoke to are not entirely happy. London is fearfully expensive, so they don't exactly have a first-world quality of life. They live in small rooms, too many of them in that space, and far away from where they work. An odd thing about people is that the quality of life of a city, all its beauty and clean air, is not as important as what they are familiar with and how a city makes them feel. India's unsightliness, chaos and visible poverty make them feel less poor than in a spectacular city like London. They have the intense sense of inferiority of being at the bottom of the society that they don't feel in the sprawling poverty of India where there are millions below them. Also, often what separates the happiness of a whole span of youth is the lottery of a good boss. Some migrants who said they were happy were those who said their employers were decent people and fair. But they were very few.

About 20 years ago, most of the migrant Indians who worked in London would claim they were students. They did come on student visas but chiefly to work. I continue to find such 'students,' but many of the migrants today come on proper work visas meant for them. There is a growing political acceptance in the UK that they need migrants for menial jobs, as the locals won't do them.

The locals don't love this entirely. They need the migrants but they may wish they were invisible, just as we expect the people who serve us to not come into conflict with the aesthetics of our beautiful homes.

One morning, I was in a Pret A Manger, watching an Englishman who was on the phone saying, "London is finished, it has gone to the dogs." He was triggered by an impoverished woman of colour, probably homeless, who decided to sit across his table. The waitress came to clear; the woman asked her to take away the croissant, which was not hers. He looked horrified even as he muttered more about the "end of London." He turned to the next table for support but only found me there. A few moments later, he came up to me and asked, "Do you know the Mayor of London, personally?" The mayor Sadiq Khan's parents were Pakistani immigrants. I still fully don't understand what he was getting at. Most Britons take care not to reveal so much of their minds.

THEIR VIEW

Lula's re-election has put Brazil's economy at risk of crash landing

His spending plans could drive inflation, hurt the currency, push up real interest rates and thus weaken economic growth

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AP

Brazil has an unfortunate habit of disappointing. Despite the country's exceptional natural-resource endowment, its growth trajectory resembles what Brazilians call the flight of a chicken (*voo de galinha*): a brief flutter followed by an inevitable fall back down to Earth. President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva's surprise re-election raises the risk of another letdown.

By the time he leaves office in 2030, Lula will have occupied the presidency for 16 (non-consecutive) years. Today, Brazil's public finances are already precarious, following nearly four years of loose fiscal policy. Public-sector debt has risen from 73.8% of gross domestic product (GDP) in 2023 to a projected 86.6% by the end of 2026.

Stabilizing debt at this level would require a sustained primary fiscal surplus of at least 1.5% of GDP. Instead, Brazil is expected to run a primary deficit of around 0.5% of GDP this year. The government's fiscal targets exclude some expenditure that contributes to borrowing requirements. Adjusting for the economic cycle and temporary fiscal measures, the International Monetary Fund puts Brazil's structural primary deficit at an estimated 1.3% of potential GDP in 2026.

Without fiscal adjustment, Brazil's debt could increase by another 10 percentage points over the next four years. But there is no sign Lula will pursue the necessary changes. In the final weeks of the campaign, he promised additional benefits, subsidies, and tax relief that local estimates suggest could cost 0.4-0.6% of GDP in 2027. Some measures can be implemented without new legislation, but their continued financing will require parliamentary agreement.

With the government's "expenditure ceiling" already fully allocated, new spending requires offsetting cuts, additional revenues, or further exceptions to its fiscal framework. None will be easy. Congress, with more than 20 parties represented, has expanded its influence over budget allocations in recent years. Legislators have strong incentives to defend existing benefits and spend any additional resources.

Furthermore, at 32.4% of GDP, Brazil's tax burden is already unusually high for an emerging economy. Congress has repeatedly resisted the government's revenue-raising efforts over the past two years, and the newly elected legislature is substantially more right wing.

Lula faces a choice between adjusting fiscal policy proactively or waiting for financial markets to force his hand. The political incentive to delay is considerable. Former president Dilma Rousseff's attempt at fiscal tightening following her 2014 re-election alienated parts of her political base and failed to prevent her impeachment in 2016. Lula may prefer to let market pressure provide the political justification for unpopular measures. But markets have an incentive to test that reluctance, raising borrowing costs and potentially forcing a more painful adjustment later.

The new Congress will also test Brazilian institutions. Over the next four years, Lula can nominate replacements for four of the Supreme Court's 11 justices and fill all nine seats on the central bank's governing board. These appointments all require Senate confirmation. Historically, this has been little more than a formality, but the Senate's rejection of Lula's Supreme Court nominee, Jorge Messias, in April—the first such rejection since 1894—suggests that the days of rubber-stamp confirmations may be over.

Both institutions will be subject to intensifying political tensions. The Supreme Court will adjudicate disagreements over executive authority, congressional spending powers and constitutionally protected expenditure. The central bank will face pressure to accommodate a fiscal position that the political system appears unwilling to correct.

This pressure is already evident. The central bank's Lula-appointed governor, Gabriel Galípolo, frustrated elements of the ruling party by resisting faster interest-rate cuts before the election. Lula now has an opportunity to reshape the bank's leadership. Yet financial markets have moved in the opposite direction: following Lula's victory, interest-rate futures began pricing renewed tightening, rather than the cuts expected before the election.

The conflict between political demands for lower rates and market demands for tighter policy could become a major test of the bank's independence.

Inflation has exceeded the upper bound of the central bank's target range for nearly two-thirds of the months since it was granted operational independence in 2021. Deteriorating fiscal credibility could raise inflation expectations and real interest rates, while weakening the currency. The resulting pressure on the banking system is also growing, with non-performing loans already rising. Further monetary tightening could aggravate credit losses and constrain lending.

Brazil's floating exchange rate, substantial foreign-exchange reserves and strong commodity exports, together with the fact that its debt is denominated predominantly in its own currency, reduce its exposure to a balance-of-payments crisis. But these do not eliminate the domestic costs of fiscal deterioration. As investors demand higher compensation for inflation and fiscal risks, borrowing costs will rise, worsening debt dynamics. Persistently high real interest rates depress private investment and weaken growth.

Political polarization makes consensus around fiscal restraint especially difficult. Brazil might face a prolonged period of high inflation, currency weakness, high real interest rates, and mediocre growth. As in the past, the Brazilian chicken will be unable to gain any lift, no matter how hard it flaps its wings.

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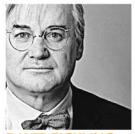
MINT CURATOR

Chokepoints have Singapore in deep water with neighbours

Walls rising in international relations imperil the small city-state



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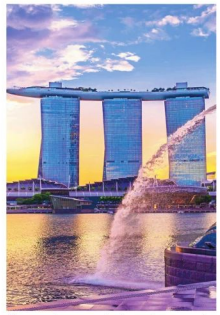

Singapore's prosperity depends on good relations with its neighbours. ISTOCKPHOTO

Stand on a clear day atop Singapore's Marina Bay Sands hotel and you can see the city-state's promise and peril in a single glance.

In the foreground, a flotilla of ships lies at anchor, a reminder of how Singapore grew rich servicing immense global trade squeezed through the chokepoint of its narrow strait. On the horizon, you can just make out the coastline of Indonesia, a country with almost 50 times Singapore's population and 2,500 times as much land. Its proximity is a reminder of how dependent that prosperity remains on good relations with Singapore's much larger neighbours.

Such issues are top of mind right now. For weeks, the view has been obscured by a haze drifting across the water from wildfires on Indonesian islands. Singapore passed laws a decade ago to combat this recurring public-health catastrophe, but has struggled to enforce them amid intransigence from its neighbour. Just days after the city announced measures against 10 Indonesian companies over the blazes this month, Jakarta started cutting pipeline supplies of natural gas to Singapore.

The decision may have an innocent explanation. Singapore has shifted towards LNG and away from Malaysian and Indonesian piped energy in recent years, anticipating that its neighbours will use more of their own supplies as their economies expand. A key link allowing Indonesia to divert gas locally was completed just weeks ago, and the affected exports represent less than 2% of daily demand.

But recent comments from Jakarta's energy distribution minister don't inspire confidence. He warned neighbouring countries to "be careful" about annoying Indonesia if they don't want their exports cut off.

The whole episode is another unpleasant reminder of the vulnerability underlying Singapore's prosperity. For more than two centuries, it has thrived as a free port, in a world where chokepoints to trade have been progressively dismantled. The city was established by the British to bypass the Dutch stronghold in Java, and its most important nation-building projects in the 1960s and 1970s repeated the model by making it a key node of emerging commercial networks, from oil refining, to container shipping, to long-haul aviation.

Throughout all that, however, Singapore has remained acutely aware of the chokeholds its larger neighbours control. Political separation from Malaysia in 1965 raised fears of water supplies being cut off. A costly programme of desalination, recycling, harvesting and reservoir-building would now allow near-self-sufficiency in a crisis.

The same can't be said for energy. Even LNG supplies could be severed by a naval blockade. Nuclear power has been considered, but comes with its own challenges: You could fit almost the entire nation inside the 20km mandatory-evacuation zone. Plans underway to install 4GW of solar panels by 2035 could leave about 5% of the country under silicon and glass, and still meet barely a 10th of electricity demand.

Separate plans to develop renewable projects and transmission lines stretching to Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia, Malaysia, Indonesia and even Australia would at least diversify electricity suppliers. But those connections could, in theory, be cut off with the flick of a switch. Singapore's driving role in establishing the power grid now taking shape across Asean can best be seen as an attempt to spread the risk across a web of mutual dependencies.

That's the hopeful vision. In a world of multilateralism, peace and trade, small maritime republics can grow fabulously wealthy as nodes for global commerce and capital. Venice, an inspiration to Singapore's founding generation, followed that model for centuries. The worrying part is what came afterwards. As Europe's commercial order gave way to an age of revolution, mass armies and nationalism, Venice's wealth proved little protection against the larger powers surrounding it. Napoleon extinguished the thousand-year republic in 1797 and it was traded back and forth like a bargaining chip between France and Austria for decades before being subsumed into the modern Italian state in 1866.

We could be entering a similar moment. The rising force in international relations is the chokepoint maximizer, looking for leverage over computer chips, critical minerals and trade flows to subdue its rivals. This year's conflict over the Strait of Hormuz is a prime example. With barriers rising to commerce, migration and capital, free ports like Singapore are in lonely waters.

"If there were no international law and order, and big fish eat small fish and small fish eat shrimps, we wouldn't exist," founding father Lee Kuan Yew mused in 2007.

Lee's successors must hope the great-power conflict brewing today is a passing storm, rather than a permanent shift in the global climate.

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MY VIEW | GENERAL DISEQUILIBRIUM

Public sector units must slow down AI implementation

RAJRISHI SINGHAL

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Much like the circular nature of many fashion trends, there seems to be a renewed interest in reviving public sector units (PSUs). The levels of interest and intensity may vary from country-to-country but PSUs are definitely finding a second lease of life. While economic exigencies—triggered by geopolitical flashpoints, broken supply chains, energy crisis, a climate emergency, tight money, heightened inflation and rising interest rates—may have necessitated a rebirth of PSUs globally, their rapid adoption of artificial intelligence (AI) has prompted an urgent need to install governance and regulatory guardrails. This is of special importance in India.

The reason is that a PSU duality exists in India which aggravates the risks. The government's public disavowal of PSUs exists cheek-by-jowl with heavy reliance on them. While many ministers have publicly stated that PSUs drain national resources, official data demonstrates that the PSU comeback movie is playing out in India as well. An annual survey of PSUs by the department of public enterprises—excluding banks, insurance companies and departmentally run companies—shows that the number of PSUs in India grew from 298 in March 2015 to 495 by March 2025, a 66% growth in 10 years.

Global data also shows a spike in PSU growth. According to the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), a Paris-based multilateral think tank, both the number of PSUs and the value of their assets in real terms have roughly doubled between 2013 and 2024. This indicates the growing significance of PSUs, especially their expanding role in the global economy. An OECD report, *Ownership and Governance of State-Owned Enterprises 2026*, further confirms the scale of PSU contribution to the global economy: 33,834 financial and non-financial PSUs had combined assets of $141 trillion in 2024, equivalent to 126% of global gross domestic product (GDP).

In terms of optics, the PSU resurgence may seem counter-intuitive when viewed against the Indian government's recent disinvestment of majority shareholding in IDBI Bank in favour of Canada-based Fairfax Holdings. While this disinvestment had been delayed for many years, its impending closure has now emboldened officials to announce a long list of assets for sale and monetization. At the same time, the government has both a monetary as well as strategic reliance on the public sector for achieving some of its targets.

The government is dependent on dividends from PSUs to meet a part of its non-tax revenue targets. Excluding surplus transfer from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the government received over ₹89,000 crore as dividend income from PSUs during 2025-26. Even if we assume that RBI's surplus transfer will remain unchanged during the current year ₹2.87 trillion, the government has budgeted to receive over ₹1.04 trillion as dividend income from PSUs during 2026-27.

Effort should be put in installing transparent guardrails to minimize governance missteps

But PSUs also have a larger strategic role. As oil companies, for example, they provide strategic price and supply stability during crises. Many manufacturing PSUs operate in sensitive areas where allowing private or foreign investment could end up endangering national security. PSU banks, given their extensive network, provide the last-mile linkages for multiple government welfare schemes, including crediting direct benefit transfers to beneficiary accounts. In times of crisis, PSU banks act like conduits for liquidity or interest rate transmission. Whenever RBI has to smoothen currency volatility, market trades are often coordinated through the foreign exchange desks of PSU banks. More importantly, funds for India's defence imports are largely routed through PSU banks.

PSUs also meet another social objective by creating employment opportunities. In the public eye, Indian PSUs were always viewed as over-staffed and unproductive. The truth is probably more nuanced. In terms of non-financial PSU employment as a percentage of total employment in the country, India does not figure among the top 20 countries in the OECD study. Surprisingly, Singapore tops the list with its PSUs having a 16% share in total employment.

This duality—publicized repudiation of PSUs while data reveals other truths—aligns well with India's fuzzy PSU governance norms. The government has drafted clear and lucid guidelines for some issues but is vague on many critical areas. For example, there is a well-defined dividend policy framework for PSUs, but there seems to be no clarity on resolving the governance muddle inherent in PSU chairmen also acting as chief executives.

These grey areas may be advantageous when coercing PSU action or deploying moral suasion for strategic reasons. However, this same ambivalence could become a liability once multiple PSUs start implementing AI to improve productivity and efficiency standards. The need for sharper and explicit regulatory guidelines has acquired some urgency, especially because the speed of implementation seems to have overtaken the need for caution and risk mitigation. As a recent McKinsey article argued, PSUs are not private businesses and, hence, the risk of getting AI wrong through hasty implementation has multiple pitfalls.

The solution, therefore, is to have clear-cut controls put in place through transparent and well-reasoned guardrails and regulatory structures.

EXTRACT

With permission to innovate or fail, staff bring new ideas

In this book excerpt, the authors explain that Tata Group's psychological support for employees helped drive innovation

Saurabh Mukherjea & Salil Desai

ISTOCKPHOTO

Titan has a unique work culture that was inculcated from the outset when a high-quality diverse team became the original founders. This culture has been honed over the years by encouraging both participation and innovation. This is bolstered by encouraging the movement of people across functions, who bring in a fresh perspective to a role, spurring innovative ideas.

Take the case of Revathi Kant. From 1995 to 2005, she was in charge of marketing and in a consumer-facing role until she was offered the role of design head for watches. In 2010, she moved on to head design, innovation and NPI for the Jewellery division and in 2017, she was elevated to chief design officer and set up the Design Excellence Centre that caters to the design needs of the entire organization. Kant's understanding of consumer needs translates into designs that are winners for Titan, from watches to jewellery to eyewear to accessories.

Ronnie Talati, who led Fastrack and later became CEO of the eyewear division, started as an accountant at Tata Press in 1976, moving to Titan alongside Xerxes Desai in 1986. Around 2005, Talati was tasked with and successfully led the revival of Fastrack. This is unique, where an employee in what is considered a support role, moves to a business function and eventually heads it...

Through their journeys across different roles and functions, employees—called Titanians—are encouraged to take risks and take ownership of their ideas.

When we interviewed Ronnie Talati about his experience heading Fastrack, he told us, "I gave my team this hook: How can we make this brand bigger than Titan? Go from 'Fastrack from Titan' to 'Titan from Fastrack'. I told them you have complete freedom and you can do whatever you want... It worked for us and we exceeded our targets month after month."

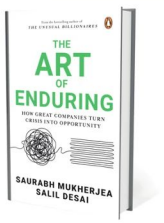
> Titan moved talent across departments, encouraging risk-taking, and providing executive backing through failures

What is interesting is that not only did Ronnie himself feel he had the empowerment to run the business as he thought fit but he in turn gave his team the same freedom.

Empowerment comes both with accountability as well as support. Both Desai and (Bhaskar) Bhat demanded performance from their employees but also backed them with psychological support throughout.

As Harish Bhat (who was a member of the leadership team of the jewellery division between 2001 and 2005, and chief operating officer of the watches division from 2006 to 2012) told us, "Bhaskar Bhat and Desai were very supportive managers. It helped the employees psychologically because they knew that if something went wrong, Titan's management would support them, stand by them. This is a Bombay House trait that I have seen, across many great leaders of the Tata Group. As long as the Group sees you giving your best to the firm, they are very supportive even during your tough times. I have learnt a lot from Bhaskar and KK (R.K. Krishna Kumar, a Tata Group veteran who passed away in January 2023) about compassion and care, not just towards senior people, but towards junior and part-time employees as well."

The resulting culture that developed was a familial one. CKV (C.K. Venkataraman) explained this aspect of culture to us at the Titan Campus in Bangalore. He said, "In the corporate sector, there is often a rat race, where your victory comes at somebody else's defeat. Or you have to climb over somebody else to succeed. That is why people get fed up and want to leave the rat race. But what if we keep aside ego? What if I celebrate your success as much as I celebrate my own? It is like what family and friends do. We are there for each other in joy and during stress. Magic can result in such a situation."



The Art of Enduring: *By Saurabh Mukherjea with Salil Desai, Penguin Random House India, 352 pages, ₹699.*

The psychological support mentioned above is crucial since failures are an inherent aspect of innovation and experimentation. CKV adds that the support for experiments that don't work sets up people to think boldly without the fear of failure. A programme such as GoldPlus (mass market jewellery for small towns), which was launched in 2005, scaled over the next twelve years and was merged with the broader Tanishq brand in 2017, is one significant example of ideas that employees bring to life.

Bhaskar Bhat pioneered this 'intrapreneurship' approach in 2004. One such programme divided a bunch of previously identified employees into cross-functional teams that focused on ideas for improving existing businesses and exploring new opportunities. Each team was led by a senior Tata Group executive and had to present their business plan to a panel consisting of managing directors from within the Tata Group as well as senior academicians from leading institutions. The panel chose GoldPlus and Eye+ for implementation.

Edited excerpt published with permission from Penguin Random House India.

Devyani Jaipuria.

MONDAY MOTIVATION

Building for the long term, not quick wins

RJ Corp's Devyani Jaipuria on creating environments where people can thrive

Shail Desai

Devyani Jaipuria's approach to work has been shaped by her parents. She learnt discipline and responsibility by accompanying her mother to the school where she worked. On other days, she observed the daily operations at Costa Coffee, a coffee chain run by her father's company, gaining hands-on exposure to the business. These early experiences sparked her interest in understanding how institutions function and what makes them thrive.

"Most assume that growing up in a business family means conversations around numbers and decisions, but what I learned was the importance of long-term thinking and building something meaningful," says Delhi-based Jaipuria, 41, director, RJ Corp-Healthcare & Education.

Jaipuria talks to *Mint Lounge* about mentorship and the importance of creating meaningful impact. Edited excerpts:

Who do you consider your mentor?

My family, starting with my grandfather, father and mother. I have also learned from teachers, colleagues and friends.

> 'Leadership has no finish line; over time, the focus shifts to purpose and resilience'

An insight you worked on with your mentor's guidance?

Meaningful impact takes time. We live in a world that often celebrates speed, but many of the most worthwhile things, whether institutions, relationships or communities, are built through patience and consistency. That perspective has influenced many of my decisions.

Some productivity principles you follow?

Age teaches you that everything cannot be equally important. Earlier in my career, I felt responsible for solving every problem myself. Over time, I've realised that leadership is often about knowing where your attention creates the greatest value and trusting others with the rest. I've also become more comfortable saying no.

A work routine you've recently developed?

For a long time, many of us believed that if we worked hard and organised ourselves well, we could stay in control. The pandemic reminded us how fragile that assumption really was. It made me less attached to the illusion of certainty.

Monday Motivation *is a series in which business leaders discuss their mentors and work ethics.*

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com

What to do when an AI layoff turns into a callback

AP
feedback@livemint.com

Companies around the world are increasingly citing artificial intelligence when slashing jobs, fueling anxiety that a lot more workers may lose their livelihoods to machines.

Microsoft, Barclays Bank and supermarket chain Kroger are among the latest entries on a growing list of companies that have announced AI-related workforce reductions this year, including the elimination of jobs deemed redundant or shed to free up money for investing in the technology.

But the job cuts of the AI era, which are affecting tens of thousands of people, occasionally have an epilogue. Some companies, after discovering that AI models, applications and agents don't perform as well as expected, end up rehiring laid-off workers to fill eliminated positions. It's unclear how common such reversals are, but they are happening often enough to acquire a nickname: the "AI boomerang."

Hiring managers in fields including finance, marketing, law and health reported earlier this year that their companies had eliminated positions primarily because of AI or automation, only to hire again for the same or similar roles, according to recruitment and staffing firm Robert Half.

The most frequently cited reasons for restoring dropped jobs included the technology needing more human oversight than anticipated and its inability to replicate institutional knowledge, the firm said.

"When you need critical thinking, collaboration, creativity, institutional knowledge, those are things that AI just can't replicate," Bill Driscoll, a senior district president at Robert Half, said.

Klarna, the Swedish provider of buy now, pay later services, began recruiting human customer service representatives again last year. CEO Sebastian Siemiatkowski acknowledged in an interview with *Bloomberg News* that the company's reliance on an AI chatbot to cut costs had gone too far. Another factor that complicates assigning more work to AI-powered tools is that company procedures for tasks such as data processing and bookkeeping are not always well documented, experts said.

Muthoot Finance

INDIA'S LARGEST GOLD LOAN NBFC

PARTICULARS	STANDALONE ₹ in Crores H1 FY 2027	H1 FY 2026	% Increase	CONSOLIDATED H1 FY 2027	H1 FY 2026	% Increase
Loan Asset (₹)	1,87,810	1,32,305	42%	2,09,317	1,47,673	42%
Total Revenue (₹)	16,445	12,153	35%	18,706	13,765	36%
Profit After Tax (₹)	5,527	4,391	26%	6,103	4,386	39%
Net Worth (₹)	42,015	31,843	32%	43,926	32,819	34%
Earnings Per Share (₹10/- each) (Basic) (₹)	137.67	109.39	26%	150.59	110.52	36%
Book Value Per Share (₹)	1,046.49	793.09	32%	1,094.05	817.33	34%

Extract Of Unaudited Standalone & Consolidated Financial Results For The Half-Year Ended September 30, 2026

Note: The above is an extract of the detailed format of Unaudited Half-Yearly Financial Results and is not a statutory advertisement required under **SEBI** guidelines. The detailed financials and investor presentation is available on the website of the Company at **www.muthootfinance.com**

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Best Workplaces™ in BFSI Great Place To Work. INDIA 2026

#TRA's Brand Trust Report 2026 *Classified by the RBI Under scale based regulatory framework

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Muthoot Family - 800 years of Business Legacy